Catechism.

YEAR 2 · UNIT 25 · DAYS 866-900

# The New Covenant Consummated: Revelation

*Revelation 1-22*

The Lamb wins. All God's covenantal promises find their Yes in Christ. New creation.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people."

REVELATION 21:3-4

*Psalms 1, 19, and 29 at the opening. Throne psalms (2, 46, 93, 97) before the bowls. Psalms 72:18-19 and 150 at the close.*

UNIT 25

# In this unit

WEEK 124

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 866 | Revelation 1:1-20 | *Reading* |
| 867 | Revelation 2:1-29 | *Reading* |
| 868 | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

WEEK 125

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 869 | Revelation 3:1-22 | *Reading* |
| 870 | Psalm 1 | *Psalm* |
| 871 | Psalm 19 | *Psalm* |
| 872 | Psalm 29 | *Psalm* |
| 873 | Revelation 4:1-5:14 | *Reading* |
| 874 | Revelation 6:1-17 | *Reading* |
| 875 | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

WEEK 126

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 876 | Revelation 7:1-8:13 | *Reading* |
| 877 | Revelation 9:1-11:19 | *Reading* |
| 878 | Psalm 141 | *Psalm* |
| 879 | Psalm 150 | *Psalm* |
| 880 | Psalm 148 | *Psalm* |
| 881 | Revelation 12:1-13:18 | *Reading* |
| 882 | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

WEEK 127

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 883 | Revelation 14:1-15:8 | *Reading* |
| 884 | Psalm 2 | *Psalm* |
| 885 | Psalm 46 | *Psalm* |
| 886 | Psalm 93 | *Psalm* |
| 887 | Psalm 97 | *Psalm* |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **888** | Revelation 16:1-21 | *Reading* |
| **889** | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

**WEEK 128**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **890** | Revelation 17:1-18:24 | *Reading* |
| **891** | Revelation 19:1-20:15 | *Reading* |
| **892** | Revelation 20:11-15; Matthew 25:31-46; 2 Corinthians 5:10 | *Doctrine* |
| **893** | Revelation 21:1-22:5 | *Reading* |
| **894** | Revelation 21:1-22:5; Isaiah 65:17-25; 2 Peter 3:10-13 | *Doctrine* |
| **895** | Revelation 22:6-21 | *Reading* |
| **896** | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

**WEEK 129**

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **897** | Psalm 72:18-19 | *Psalm* |
| **898** | Psalm 150 | *Psalm* |
| **899** | Review and Reflection | *Review* |
| **900** | Sabbath Rest | *Sabbath* |

DAY 866 · WEEK 124

# Revelation 1:1-20

*The vision of Christ, the risen Lord among his churches*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 20 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 1:1-20 in one sitting. This is the opening of the last book of the Bible. Notice how often the language echoes the Old Testament, and how the book begins and ends with Jesus Christ, not with a timetable of events.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The apostle John, now an old man, was exiled on the island of Patmos in the Aegean Sea around AD 95, during the reign of the emperor Domitian, when emperor worship was pressing on the churches of Asia Minor. Revelation is a letter to seven real churches, a prophecy, and an apocalypse: a kind of writing that uses symbols and visions to unveil what is true behind the surface of history. It is full of images drawn from Daniel, Ezekiel, Isaiah, Zechariah, Exodus, and the Psalms, and nearly every verse echoes the Old Testament. It is not a puzzle to decode but a vision to be seen and a book to be heard. Its message to suffering believers is: Jesus reigns, and the Lamb wins.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. “Blessed is the one who reads aloud the words of this prophecy, and blessed are those who hear, and who keep what is written in it, for the time is near” (v. 3).
2. “To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood” (v. 5).
3. “Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him” (v. 7).
4. “I am the Alpha and the Omega, says the Lord God, who is and who was and who is to come, the Almighty” (v. 8).
5. “I, John, your brother and partner in the tribulation and the kingdom and the patient endurance that are in Jesus” (v. 9).

6. “From his mouth came a sharp two-edged sword, and his face was like the sun shining in full strength” (v. 16).
7. “I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades” (v. 18).
8. “The seven stars are the angels of the seven churches, and the seven lampstands are the seven churches” (v. 20).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The book begins, “The revelation of Jesus Christ.” The Greek word is apokalypsis, an unveiling. It is a revelation from Jesus and about Jesus. And it begins with a blessing, the first of seven in the book: “Blessed is the one who reads aloud the words of this prophecy, and blessed are those who hear, and who keep what is written in it.” It was meant to be read aloud in the churches and obeyed. “The time is near” means that its message presses on every generation.

The greeting is to the seven churches in Asia, from the triune God: from him “who is and who was and who is to come” (the Father), from the “seven spirits who are before his throne” (the Holy Spirit in his fullness), and from Jesus Christ, “the faithful witness, the firstborn of the dead, and the ruler of kings on earth.” Notice the three titles: he witnessed faithfully, he rose first, and he rules even over the emperor. Then a burst of praise: “To him who loves us and has freed us from our sins by his blood and made us a kingdom, priests to his God and Father, to him be glory and dominion forever and ever. Amen.” This borrows the language of Exodus 19:6 and applies it to the church, as Peter does. Then a promise combining Daniel 7:13 and Zechariah 12:10: “Behold, he is coming with the clouds, and every eye will see him, even those who pierced him, and all tribes of the earth will wail on account of him.” And God himself speaks: “I am the Alpha and the Omega,” the first and last letters of the Greek alphabet, the beginning and the end.

John describes himself as a “brother and partner in the tribulation and the kingdom and the patient endurance that are in Jesus.” Those three are always together for Christians: suffering, kingdom, and endurance. He was on Patmos “on account of the word of God and the testimony of Jesus.” On the Lord’s day (Sunday, the day of Christ’s resurrection) he was “in the Spirit” and heard a loud voice like a trumpet telling him to write what he sees to the seven churches.

He turns and sees seven golden lampstands, and in the midst “one like a son of man” (Daniel 7:13). His description is overwhelming: a long robe and golden sash, hair white like wool, eyes like a flame of fire, feet like burnished bronze, voice like the roar of many waters, in his right hand seven stars, from his mouth a sharp two-edged sword, and his face like the sun in

full strength. Almost every feature recalls the Old Testament's descriptions of God and the Ancient of Days. Jesus is portrayed as divine, glorious, and terrifying. John falls at his feet as though dead. But Jesus lays his right hand on him and says, "Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades." The same one who is glorious is the one who died. His keys mean that death and the grave answer to him. No one needs to fear them.

He tells John to write what he has seen, what is now, and what will take place after this. The seven stars and lampstands are explained: the stars are the angels (or messengers) of the churches, and the lampstands are the churches themselves. Jesus walks among his churches. He knows them, holds them, and judges them. Interpreters have understood Revelation in different ways: as largely about events in the first century (preterist), as the sweep of church history (historicist), as symbols of the spiritual struggle across all ages (idealist), or as largely about events at the end of history (futurist). Many thoughtful readers combine elements of these. In every approach, the center is clear: Christ is Lord, and his church is held in his hand.

STEP 5

## Connection

Daniel 7:9-14 and 10:5-6 stand behind the vision of the Son of Man. Exodus 19:5-6 is the source of "a kingdom, priests." Zechariah 12:10 and Matthew 24:30 relate to verse 7. Isaiah 41:4 and 44:6 are behind the Alpha and Omega and the first and last. Ezekiel 1 and Isaiah 6 show similar overwhelming visions. John 1:1-18 and Philippians 2:9-11 speak of Christ's glory. Hebrews 2:14-15 speaks of the defeat of death. Acts 4:12 and Romans 14:9 speak of Christ's lordship. 1 Peter 2:9 says believers are a royal priesthood. Zechariah 4 describes the lampstand.

STEP 6

## Application

Read the book aloud today, as the blessing in verse 3 invites. Even reading the first chapter aloud will help you hear it as its first audience did.

Picture the risen Christ walking among your church. What would he commend, and what would he correct?

When you fear death or what is ahead, say verse 18 to yourself: the living one holds the keys.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Worship Jesus, the faithful witness and ruler of kings.

Thank him for loving you and freeing you from your sins.

Ask him to keep you from fear, and listen to him say, “Fear not.”

**MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 124**

“Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades.”

**REVELATION 1:17-18**

DAY 867 · WEEK 124

# Revelation 2:1-29

*Letters to Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, Thyatira*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 29 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 2:1-29. Jesus speaks to four of the seven churches: Ephesus, Smyrna, Pergamum, and Thyatira. Notice the pattern in each letter: a description of Christ, what he knows, what he commends or criticizes, a call to listen, and a promise to the one who conquers.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The seven churches were real congregations in cities of Asia Minor, arranged along a circular road. Each letter reflects its city's setting: Ephesus, a great port and the center of the cult of Artemis; Smyrna, loyal to Rome, with a hostile Jewish community; Pergamum, with temples to Zeus, Asclepius, and the emperor; Thyatira, a city of trade guilds that required participation in pagan feasts. The letters also work as a mirror for churches of every age, because the problems of love grown cold, persecution, compromise, and tolerance of false teaching never go away.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "But I have this against you, that you have abandoned the love you had at first" (v. 4).
2. "Remember therefore from where you have fallen; repent, and do the works you did at first" (v. 5).
3. "To the one who conquers I will grant to eat of the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God" (v. 7).
4. "Be faithful unto death, and I will give you the crown of life" (v. 10).
5. "Therefore repent. If not, I will come to you soon and war against them with the sword of my mouth" (v. 16).

6. “A white stone, with a new name written on the stone that no one knows except the one who receives it” (v. 17).
7. “I am he who searches mind and heart” (v. 23).
8. “And I will give him the morning star” (v. 28).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

To Ephesus, Jesus is the one who walks among the lampstands. He commends their works, toil, patient endurance, and refusal to tolerate evil, and their testing of false apostles. “But I have this against you, that you have abandoned the love you had at first.” They had kept the doctrine but lost the love. The remedy has three parts: “Remember therefore from where you have fallen; repent, and do the works you did at first.” If not, he will remove their lampstand. Correct doctrine without warm love is a dying church. The promise to the conqueror: “I will grant to eat of the tree of life, which is in the paradise of God,” the restoration of Eden.

To Smyrna, Jesus is “the first and the last, who died and came to life.” There is no criticism, only comfort. “I know your tribulation and your poverty (but you are rich).” They are slandered and about to suffer imprisonment. “Do not fear what you are about to suffer… Be faithful unto death, and I will give you the crown of life.” Polycarp, the bishop of Smyrna, was martyred about sixty years later, saying he had served Christ eighty-six years. The promise: the conqueror “will not be hurt by the second death.” The first death can touch the body; the second cannot touch the faithful.

To Pergamum, Jesus has “the sharp two-edged sword.” The church lives “where Satan’s throne is,” probably a reference to the center of emperor worship. They have held fast his name, even when Antipas, “my faithful witness,” was killed. But some hold the teaching of Balaam (who led Israel into idolatry and sexual immorality, Numbers 25) and the Nicolaitans. The command: “Therefore repent.” The conqueror will receive “hidden manna” and a white stone with a new name, signs of provision and of acceptance and a personal identity from Christ.

To Thyatira, Jesus is the Son of God, “whose eyes are like a flame of fire.” This is the only place in Revelation he is called Son of God. The church is growing in love, faith, service, and patience, but “you tolerate that woman Jezebel,” who calls herself a prophetess and leads his servants into sexual immorality and food offered to idols. Jesus gave her time to repent, but she refuses. He warns: “I am he who searches mind and heart, and I will give to each of you as your works deserve.” Those who have not followed her teaching are to hold fast until he comes. The conqueror receives authority over the nations, sharing Christ’s rule (Psalm 2:8-9), and “the morning star,” which is Christ himself (22:16).

Each letter ends: “He who has an ear, let him hear what the Spirit says to the churches.” The promises to the conqueror are not for a special class of believers. In 1 John 5:4-5, everyone born of God conquers through faith in Jesus. The conqueror is the persevering believer. Christ knows what we face, and he will keep his promises.

STEP 5

## Connection

Acts 19 tells of the founding of the church in Ephesus. Ephesians 6:23-24 speaks of love for the Lord. Genesis 2:9 and 3:22-24 describe the tree of life. Revelation 20:6 and 21:8 speak of the second death. Numbers 22-25 and 31:16 are the story of Balaam. 1 Kings 16:31-33 and 2 Kings 9 tell of Jezebel. Psalm 2:7-9 is the background of authority over the nations. 1 Corinthians 8 and 10:14-22 discuss food offered to idols. Jeremiah 17:10 and Romans 8:27 speak of God searching hearts. 2 Peter 1:19 and Revelation 22:16 mention the morning star. 1 John 5:4-5 says every believer conquers.

STEP 6

## Application

Ask if your love for Christ and for his people is what it was at first. If not, follow the three steps: remember, repent, and return.

If you face pressure or ridicule for your faith, take the words to Smyrna to heart: do not fear; be faithful.

What teaching or practice do you tolerate that Christ would not? Bring it to him.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Thank Jesus that he walks among his churches and knows your works.
- Confess where you have compromised.
- Ask him to give you endurance and faithfulness.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 124

“Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades.”

REVELATION 1:17-18

DAY 868 · WEEK 124

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Revelation 1:17-18 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"Fear not, I am the first and the last, and the living one. I died, and behold I am alive forevermore, and I have the keys of Death and Hades."

REVELATION 1:17-18

REST

## Meditation

John, the beloved disciple who once leaned on Jesus' chest at supper, falls at his feet as though dead when he sees the risen Christ in glory. Even for a friend, the glory of the Lord is overwhelming. And then Jesus lays his right hand on him and speaks the most common command in the Bible: "Fear not."

The reason is who Jesus is: the first and the last, the living one. He has always been and will always be. And his credentials are astonishing: "I died, and behold I am alive forevermore." He has gone through the one door that no one else returned from. He holds the keys of Death and Hades.

If he holds the keys, then death is not a locked door he cannot open; the grave has an owner, and he is your Savior. When fear comes today, put your hand in his right hand, the one he laid on John, and hear him say again, "Fear not."

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week you began the book of Revelation. Chapter 1 unveiled the risen Christ: the faithful witness, the firstborn of the dead, and the ruler of kings, the Alpha and Omega, the Son of Man in glory with a sword in his mouth and the keys of Death and Hades in his hand, walking among his churches. Chapter 2 gave his letters to Ephesus (love grown cold), Smyrna (faithful in suffering), Pergamum (compromise with the world), and Thyatira (tolerating false teaching), each with a promise to the one who conquers: the tree of life, the crown of life, the hidden manna and white stone, and the morning star.

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

John saw Jesus in glory and fell as though dead, yet Jesus touched him and said, “Fear not.” What fear do you most need Jesus to speak that word over right now?

Ephesus had sound doctrine but had lost its first love. Honestly, how would you describe your love for Christ and for his people right now, and what is one step toward returning to the works you did at first?

Jesus says to the conqueror at Smyrna that he will receive the crown of life. How does the promise that Christ himself died and came to life help you face suffering or fear of death?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank Jesus that he is the first and the last, the living one.

Thank him that he holds the keys of death and Hades.

Rest in his hand.

DAY 869 · WEEK 125

# Revelation 3:1-22

*Letters to Sardis, Philadelphia, Laodicea*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 22 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 3:1-22. Jesus speaks to the last three of the seven churches: Sardis, Philadelphia, and Laodicea. Notice that two churches receive only criticism, one receives only praise, and the best-known verse in the chapter is addressed to a church, not to an individual.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Sardis was a wealthy city that had twice fallen to surprise attacks because its defenders thought the acropolis was unassailable. Philadelphia, a small and relatively weak city, was known for earthquakes and for being a gateway to the east. Laodicea was a rich banking and textile center, famous for its black wool, an eye salve, and a water supply piped in from hot springs and cold streams that arrived lukewarm. Jesus addresses each church using images drawn from its own setting.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. “You have the reputation of being alive, but you are dead” (v. 1).
2. “Wake up, and strengthen what remains and is about to die” (v. 2).
3. “I have set before you an open door, which no one is able to shut” (v. 8).
4. “Because you are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold, I will spit you out of my mouth” (v. 16).
5. “For you say, I am rich, I have prospered, and I need nothing” (v. 17).
6. “Those whom I love, I reprove and discipline, so be zealous and repent” (v. 19).

7. “Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me” (v. 20).

8. “The one who conquers, I will grant him to sit with me on my throne, as I also conquered and sat down with my Father on his throne” (v. 21).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

To Sardis, Jesus holds “the seven spirits of God and the seven stars.” He says, “I know your works. You have the reputation of being alive, but you are dead.” It is the harshest letter, with no commendation. The church looked fine from outside but was spiritually asleep, as the city had been when it fell. “Wake up, and strengthen what remains and is about to die.” They are to remember what they received and heard, keep it, and repent. If not, he will come like a thief. A few in Sardis have not soiled their garments, and “they will walk with me in white, for they are worthy.” The conqueror will be clothed in white, and Jesus “will never blot his name out of the book of life,” but will confess his name before the Father and his angels. This is a promise of security for the faithful.

To Philadelphia, Jesus is “the holy one, the true one, who has the key of David, who opens and no one will shut.” There is only praise. “I know that you have but little power, and yet you have kept my word and have not denied my name.” Christ has set before them “an open door, which no one is able to shut,” perhaps for gospel opportunity. He will make those who slander them come and bow down before their feet, and know that he has loved them. “Because you have kept my word about patient endurance, I will keep you from the hour of trial that is coming on the whole world.” Interpreters differ on whether this means being kept through trials (as in John 17:15) or removed from them (as taught in some forms of premillennialism); either way, the promise is that Christ guards the faithful. The conqueror will be made “a pillar in the temple of my God,” never to go out of it, and will have written on him the name of God, of the city of God, and Christ’s own new name.

To Laodicea, Jesus is “the Amen, the faithful and true witness, the beginning of God’s creation.” There is no commendation here either. “I know your works: you are neither cold nor hot. Would that you were either cold or hot! So, because you are lukewarm, and neither hot nor cold, I will spit you out of my mouth.” Laodicea’s water came lukewarm from afar: not refreshing like cold water or healing like hot. The church’s works were useless. Their self-image was prosperous: “I am rich, I have prospered, and I need nothing.” But Jesus says they are “wretched, pitiable, poor, blind, and naked.” Their remedy is to buy from him gold refined by fire, white garments, and eye salve, answers to the city’s banking, textile, and medical fame. “Those whom I love, I reprove and discipline, so be zealous and repent.”

Then the most famous verse: “Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and eat with him, and he with me.” This is often used as an invitation to unbelievers, but its original setting is Christ knocking on the door of his own church. He is on the outside of a congregation that thinks it needs nothing. The invitation to repent and renew fellowship, symbolized by a shared meal, applies to every church and every believer who has drifted. The final promise is the highest of all: “The one who conquers, I will grant him to sit with me on my throne, as I also conquered and sat down with my Father on his throne.” The letters end as they began, with the call to hear. Christ does not just judge his churches; he loves them and calls them back.

STEP 5

## Connection

Matthew 24:42-44 and 1 Thessalonians 5:2-6 speak of coming like a thief. Isaiah 22:22 is the source of the key of David. Isaiah 45:14 and 49:23 are behind the bowing at their feet. Isaiah 60:14 speaks of enemies bowing. John 17:15 prays that the Father would keep believers from the evil one. Colossians 4:13-16 mentions Laodicea. Hosea 12:8 and 1 Corinthians 4:8 speak of self-satisfaction. Proverbs 3:11-12 and Hebrews 12:5-11 speak of the Lord’s discipline. Song of Solomon 5:2 has a similar knocking at the door. Luke 12:35-37 and John 14:23 speak of fellowship with Christ. Luke 22:28-30 promises a share in his throne.

STEP 6

## Application

Honestly ask: if people could see your inner spiritual life, would they say you are alive? Pick one thing to strengthen that is about to die.

Open the door to Christ for an area of your life where you have been self-sufficient. Tell him you need him.

Thank Christ for the discipline you may be experiencing as a sign of his love.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ask Jesus to wake you up where you are asleep.
- Thank him for the open door he has set before you.
- Ask him for the courage to open your door to him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 125

“Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!”

REVELATION 5:12

DAY 870 · WEEK 125

# Psalm 1

*Blessed is the man, the two ways*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 1. It is the gateway to the whole book of Psalms, and its picture of a tree by streams of water returns in the last chapter of the Bible. Notice the two ways, the two destinies, and the one who delights in God's law.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 1 has no title. It stands as the introduction to the Psalter, setting out the choice that all of the other psalms assume: there are two ways to live, and they lead to two ends. It reads like a wisdom poem, in the tradition of Proverbs and Deuteronomy 30. We now return to it as we begin the last book of the Bible, where the same two ways appear for the last time, in the tree of life and in the judgment of the wicked.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Blessed is the man who walks not in the counsel of the wicked, nor stands in the way of sinners, nor sits in the seat of scoffers" (v. 1).
2. "But his delight is in the law of the LORD, and on his law he meditates day and night" (v. 2).
3. "He is like a tree planted by streams of water that yields its fruit in its season" (v. 3).
4. "In all that he does, he prospers" (v. 3).
5. "The wicked are not so, but are like chaff that the wind drives away" (v. 4).
6. "Therefore the wicked will not stand in the judgment" (v. 5).
7. "For the LORD knows the way of the righteous" (v. 6).
8. "But the way of the wicked will perish" (v. 6).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The first word is “Blessed,” meaning deeply, lastingly happy. The blessed man is first described by what he avoids. Notice the progression: he walks, then stands, then sits. First he takes the counsel of the wicked, then he stands in the way of sinners, then he settles into the seat of scoffers. Sin starts as a casual step and becomes a way of life. The blessed person refuses to start down that road.

What he does instead is delight in God’s law: “on his law he meditates day and night.” The word “law” is torah, God’s instruction, and it points to the whole of God’s revealed word. Delight means that it is not merely a duty; it is a pleasure. Meditation means that he turns it over and over, as a cow chews the cud. The result is a picture of stability and fruit: “He is like a tree planted by streams of water that yields its fruit in its season, and its leaf does not wither.” The tree is planted, not wild; its roots reach the water; it does not wither in drought. “In all that he does, he prospers.” This is not a promise of worldly wealth for everyone who reads the Bible; it is a description of a life that, in God’s sight, succeeds and bears lasting fruit. Jeremiah 17:7-8 uses the same image.

By contrast, “The wicked are not so.” They are like chaff, the weightless husk the wind blows away. They have no roots, no fruit, no future. “Therefore the wicked will not stand in the judgment, nor sinners in the congregation of the righteous.” The psalm ends with the reason: “For the LORD knows the way of the righteous, but the way of the wicked will perish.” God knows, which means he watches over and cares for the way of the righteous, as in the phrase “The LORD knows those who are his.”

Reading this psalm in the light of Christ, we see that he is the truly blessed man. He alone never walked in the counsel of the wicked, and his delight was in the law of the LORD (Psalm 40:8). He is the tree whose fruit never fails. And in Revelation 22:2, the tree of life stands by the river of the water of life, bearing twelve kinds of fruit, with leaves for the healing of the nations. Those who are in Christ are planted by the streams of water, and one day will eat of that tree. The two ways of Psalm 1 are the two ways of the whole Bible, and the last chapters of Revelation show where each ends.

STEP 5

## Connection

Jeremiah 17:7-8 uses the image of a tree by water. Joshua 1:8 commands meditating on the law day and night. Psalm 119 is an extended meditation on the law. Deuteronomy 30:15-20 sets before Israel life and death. Proverbs 4:14-19 describes two paths. Matthew 7:13-14

speaks of the two ways. Psalm 40:6-8 and Hebrews 10:5-9 show Christ delighting to do God's will. John 15:1-8 speaks of abiding and bearing fruit. Genesis 2:9 and Revelation 2:7, 22:2 mention the tree of life. Matthew 3:12 speaks of chaff.

STEP 6

## Application

Ask what counsel you have been listening to, and where you may be starting to "walk, stand, or sit" in a place you should not.

Choose a short passage and meditate on it throughout the day. Return to it when you have a spare moment.

Thank Christ that he is the blessed man in your place, and that his roots reach to the stream of life.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Tell God you want to be blessed as his word describes.
- Ask him to keep you from the counsel of the wicked.
- Ask him to root you in his word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 125

"Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!"

REVELATION 5:12

DAY 871 · WEEK 125

# Psalm 19

*The heavens declare; the law revives the soul*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 19. Notice the three movements: the voice of creation (vv. 1-6), the perfection of God's word (vv. 7-11), and the prayer of a servant who asks to be cleansed and made acceptable (vv. 12-14).

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 19 is a psalm of David. C. S. Lewis called it one of the greatest poems in the Psalter. It joins two ways in which God speaks: through the heavens (general revelation) and through his word (special revelation). We read the first part earlier in connection with Paul's use of it in Romans 10. Today we read it as a whole, as we move into Revelation, where the whole creation and God's written word are central.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork" (v. 1).
2. "Day to day pours out speech, and night to night reveals knowledge" (v. 2).
3. "The law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul" (v. 7).
4. "The precepts of the LORD are right, rejoicing the heart" (v. 8).
5. "More to be desired are they than gold, even much fine gold; sweeter also than honey and drippings of the honeycomb" (v. 10).
6. "Moreover, by them is your servant warned; in keeping them there is great reward" (v. 11).
7. "Who can discern his errors? Declare me innocent from hidden faults" (v. 12).

8 “Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable in your sight, O LORD, my rock and my redeemer” (v. 14).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm begins with the sky: “The heavens declare the glory of God, and the sky above proclaims his handiwork.” The created order is a continual testimony. “Day to day pours out speech, and night to night reveals knowledge. There is no speech, nor are there words, whose voice is not heard.” Creation speaks without words and in every language, and “their voice goes out through all the earth.” In the heavens, God has set a tent for the sun, which rises like a bridegroom and runs its course like a strong man with joy. “There is nothing hidden from its heat.” This general revelation shows the power and glory of the Creator but does not tell us how to be saved. For that we need his word.

The second part turns to the word, with six names for it (law, testimony, precepts, commandment, fear, rules) and six effects. “The law of the LORD is perfect, reviving the soul; the testimony of the LORD is sure, making wise the simple; the precepts of the LORD are right, rejoicing the heart; the commandment of the LORD is pure, enlightening the eyes; the fear of the LORD is clean, enduring forever; the rules of the LORD are true, and righteous altogether.” This is how the Bible works: it restores the weary, makes the simple wise, brings joy, gives light, endures forever, and proves true. “More to be desired are they than gold, even much fine gold; sweeter also than honey and drippings of the honeycomb.” The psalmist treasures the word more than wealth and enjoys it more than sweets.

The third part is personal. Having seen the glory of God in creation and in his word, the psalmist sees himself. “Who can discern his errors? Declare me innocent from hidden faults. Keep back your servant also from presumptuous sins; let them not have dominion over me! Then I shall be blameless, and innocent of great transgression.” The word is a mirror that shows sins we cannot see by ourselves. He asks for cleansing from the hidden and the willful. And he ends with a prayer that has been prayed by preachers for centuries: “Let the words of my mouth and the meditation of my heart be acceptable in your sight, O LORD, my rock and my redeemer.”

The movement from the stars to the Scripture to the sinner is the movement of faith. We look up and see glory, we look into God’s word and see grace, and we look inward and see our need. In Revelation, the creation praises its Creator (4:11; 5:13), the book is opened, and the redeemer is the Lamb. The one who is our rock is also our redeemer.

STEP 5

## Connection

Romans 1:18-20 and 10:18 draw on creation's testimony. Psalm 8, 33, and 104 also praise God in creation. Psalm 119:97-105 and Deuteronomy 4:6-8 praise the law. 2 Timothy 3:15-17 describes the use of Scripture. Hebrews 4:12 describes the word as living. Psalm 90:8 and 139:23-24 speak of hidden sin. Psalm 51:1-12 asks for cleansing. John 8:12 and 1 John 1:5 link light to God. Revelation 4:11 and 5:13 have creation praising God. Isaiah 41:14 and 44:6 call God redeemer.

STEP 6

## Application

Step outside today and look at the sky. Let it speak. Tell God what it says to you about him.

Read one of the descriptions of the law (vv. 7-9) and pray for the effect you most need: reviving, wisdom, joy, or light.

Pray verse 14 before you speak or write something important.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Thank God for speaking through the heavens and through his word.
- Ask him to cleanse you from hidden faults.
- Pray Psalm 19:14 as your own.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 125

"Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!"

REVELATION 5:12

DAY 872 · WEEK 125

# Psalm 29

*The voice of the LORD, Revelation's thunders*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 29. The psalm is built around the phrase "the voice of the LORD," repeated seven times. Read it aloud and listen for the sound of a storm moving across the land.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 29 is a psalm of David describing a thunderstorm that sweeps in from the Mediterranean, crosses the mountains of Lebanon, and moves down to the wilderness of Kadesh in the south. It was probably used in worship at the temple. Canaanite religion said that Baal, the storm god, ruled the thunder. This psalm declares that the thunder is the voice of the LORD, and only he is the God of glory. It stands next to Revelation's thunders and the heavenly worship of chapters 4 and 5.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Ascribe to the LORD, O heavenly beings, ascribe to the LORD glory and strength" (v. 1).
2. "Worship the LORD in the splendor of holiness" (v. 2).
3. "The voice of the LORD is over the waters; the God of glory thunders" (v. 3).
4. "The voice of the LORD is powerful; the voice of the LORD is full of majesty" (v. 4).
5. "The voice of the LORD breaks the cedars" (v. 5).
6. "In his temple all cry, Glory!" (v. 9).
7. "The LORD sits enthroned over the flood; the LORD sits enthroned as king forever" (v. 10).
8. "May the LORD give strength to his people! May the LORD bless his people with peace!" (v. 11).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm begins in heaven: “Ascribe to the LORD, O heavenly beings, ascribe to the LORD glory and strength. Ascribe to the LORD the glory due his name; worship the LORD in the splendor of holiness.” Even the angels are called to give God the glory that belongs to him. The word “ascribe” means to give him what is already his.

Then seven times we hear the voice of the LORD. His voice is “over the waters,” that is, over the sea and the storm clouds. It “is powerful” and “full of majesty.” It “breaks the cedars,” the greatest trees of the ancient world. It makes Lebanon and Sirion (Mount Hermon) “skip like a calf, and Sirion like a young wild ox.” The mountains jump at his voice. It “flashes forth flames of fire,” meaning lightning, and it “shakes the wilderness.” The voice “makes the deer give birth and strips the forests bare.” Everything in creation trembles. And in the middle of the storm, “in his temple all cry, Glory!” Only in the temple do people understand what the thunder means: God is speaking.

The first half is about the voice of the LORD in nature, and the last is about the LORD enthroned: “The LORD sits enthroned over the flood; the LORD sits enthroned as king forever.” The flood recalls Noah, and the chaos waters of creation. God is not threatened by floods; he sits above them. He is king forever.

The last verse is the application: “May the LORD give strength to his people! May the LORD bless his people with peace!” The God whose voice shakes the mountains is the God who gives his people strength and peace. Power is not a threat to those who belong to him; it is their shelter.

In Revelation, the same imagery is used. From the throne come “flashes of lightning, and rumblings and peals of thunder” (4:5). Seven thunders speak in 10:3-4. In 19:6, the great multitude hears “the sound of many waters and like the sound of mighty peals of thunder, crying out, Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns.” In Christ, the voice of God has come in its fullest form. Hebrews 12:26 says that his voice shook the earth then, and will shake not only the earth but also the heavens.

STEP 5

## Connection

Exodus 19:16-19 and 20:18-19 describe the voice of God at Sinai. Job 37:2-5 and 38:1 describe God’s thunder. Psalm 18:13-15 and 77:18 also describe thunder. 1 Chronicles 16:28-29 echoes the call to ascribe glory. Genesis 6-9 is the flood. Psalm 93:3-4 and 104:7 also speak of the waters. Revelation 4:5, 8:5, 10:3-4, and 19:6 mention thunder. Hebrews 12:25-28 says God’s voice shakes heaven and earth. John 12:28-29 records a voice from heaven that some took for thunder. Numbers 6:24-26 pronounces blessing with peace.

STEP 6

## Application

Next time you hear thunder, pause and say verse 3 and 10. The God who thunders is your Father.

Practice “ascribing” today: give God the glory when something goes well, instead of keeping it.

Pray verse 11 for your church and family.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Ascribe glory and strength to God, in your own words.
- Worship him in the splendor of holiness.
- Ask him to give you his peace.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 125

“Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!”

REVELATION 5:12

DAY 873 · WEEK 125

# Revelation 4:1-5:14

*The throne room; the Lamb takes the scroll*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 25 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 4:1-5:14. John is taken up into the throne room of heaven. Notice the worship around the throne, the sealed scroll, the weeping that turns to praise, and the surprising appearance of the Lamb.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

After the letters to the churches, John is invited through an open door into heaven, where the rest of the book is seen from the perspective of the throne. The scene recalls Isaiah 6, Ezekiel 1, and Daniel 7. The throne is the central fact of the universe, and the question of Revelation 4 and 5 is: who is worthy to carry out God's plan for history, as symbolized in the scroll? For persecuted Christians who feel that Caesar holds power, this is the vision they need.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "At once I was in the Spirit, and behold, a throne stood in heaven, with one seated on the throne" (4:2).
2. "Holy, holy, holy, is the Lord God Almighty, who was and is and is to come!" (4:8).
3. "Worthy are you, our Lord and God, to receive glory and honor and power, for you created all things" (4:11).
4. "Weep no more; behold, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered" (5:5).
5. "A Lamb standing, as though it had been slain" (5:6).
6. "For you were slain, and by your blood you ransomed people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation" (5:9).

7. “Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!” (5:12).

8. “To him who sits on the throne and to the Lamb be blessing and honor and glory and might forever and ever!” (5:13).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

John is called up through an open door and immediately is in the Spirit before a throne. The one seated on it is described only in terms of gemstones, jasper and carnelian, with a rainbow like an emerald around it. He is not described in human form, because he is beyond description. Around the throne are twenty-four elders on thrones, dressed in white with golden crowns, probably representing the whole people of God (the twelve tribes and twelve apostles). Lightning and thunder come from the throne. Before it burn seven torches, which are the seven spirits of God, and there is a sea of glass like crystal. Four living creatures, full of eyes, like the seraphim of Isaiah 6, never cease to say: “Holy, holy, holy, is the Lord God Almighty, who was and is and is to come!” When they give glory, the elders fall down and cast their crowns before the throne, saying: “Worthy are you, our Lord and God, to receive glory and honor and power, for you created all things, and by your will they existed and were created.” Heaven’s first act is worship of the Creator.

In chapter 5, John sees in the right hand of the one on the throne “a scroll written within and on the back, sealed with seven seals.” This is a scroll of God’s purposes for the world, a will or deed that must be opened for its judgments and blessings to come to pass. A mighty angel asks, “Who is worthy to open the scroll and break its seals?” No one in heaven or on earth or under the earth is found worthy. John weeps loudly. If no one can open it, God’s purposes for history, for his people, and for creation cannot be carried out. But an elder says, “Weep no more; behold, the Lion of the tribe of Judah, the Root of David, has conquered, so that he can open the scroll and its seven seals.”

John listens for the Lion, but when he looks, he sees “a Lamb standing, as though it had been slain, with seven horns and with seven eyes, which are the seven spirits of God sent out into all the earth.” He heard “Lion” and saw “Lamb.” This is the central image of the book: Christ conquers by sacrifice, through his death. He bears the marks of slaughter but stands alive. His seven horns signify complete power, and his seven eyes complete knowledge. He takes the scroll from the right hand of the one seated on the throne, and the whole of heaven erupts in a new song: “Worthy are you to take the scroll and to open its seals, for you were slain, and by your blood you ransomed people for God from every tribe and language and people and nation, and you have made them a kingdom and priests to our God, and they shall reign on the earth.”

Then the circle of praise widens: myriads of angels, “ten thousand times ten thousand and thousands of thousands,” saying with a loud voice: “Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!” And finally every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and in the sea: “To him who sits on the throne and to the Lamb be blessing and honor and glory and might forever and ever!” The four living creatures say “Amen,” and the elders fall down and worship. The Lamb shares the worship given to the one on the throne. This is the best answer to the question of what Revelation is about: the Lamb who was slain holds the scroll of history.

STEP 5

## Connection

Isaiah 6:1-4 and Ezekiel 1 are the sources for the throne and the creatures. Daniel 7:9-10 shows the Ancient of Days enthroned. Genesis 49:9-10 is the background of the Lion of Judah, and Isaiah 11:1, 10 of the Root of David. Isaiah 53:7 and John 1:29 speak of the Lamb. Exodus 12 is the Passover lamb. Daniel 12:4 and Ezekiel 2:9-10 mention sealed scrolls. Philippians 2:9-11 describes every creature confessing Christ. Colossians 1:15-20 describes his supremacy. Ephesians 1:9-10 speaks of God’s plan for the fullness of time. Revelation 1:5-6 uses the same kingdom and priests language.

STEP 6

## Application

Spend five minutes simply worshiping today, with no requests. Use the words of 4:8, 4:11, and 5:12.

When you feel that history is out of control, picture the throne and the Lamb holding the scroll.

Think about how Jesus conquered. How might it change how you respond to a situation where you want to win?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Worship God as holy, holy, holy.
- Thank the Lamb who was slain and has ransomed people for God.
- Add your voice to the song of every creature.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 125

“Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!”

REVELATION 5:12

DAY 874 · WEEK 125

# Revelation 6:1-17

*The seven seals, the four horsemen*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 17 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 6:1-17. The Lamb opens the first six of the seven seals. Read it as a picture of the forces at work in history between Christ's first coming and his return, and notice the cry of the martyrs and the response of the world to the wrath of the Lamb.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

This is the beginning of the unfolding of the scroll, with four horsemen modeled on Zechariah 1 and 6, and with words that recall Jesus' own description of the age in Matthew 24: conquest, war, famine, death, persecution, and cosmic upheaval. Interpreters have read the seals in different ways: as events leading up to the end (futurist), as the general pattern of the whole age (idealist), as events of the first century (preterist), or as the course of history (historicist). Many see in them what Jesus described as "the beginning of the birth pains" (Matthew 24:8). In every view, it is the Lamb who opens each seal, which means that all of history is under his authority.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Now I watched when the Lamb opened one of the seven seals" (v. 1).
2. "And its rider had a bow, and a crown was given to him, and he came out conquering, and to conquer" (v. 2).
3. "It was granted to its rider to take peace from the earth, so that people should slay one another" (v. 4).
4. "And do not harm the oil and wine!" (v. 6).
5. "And its rider's name was Death, and Hades followed him" (v. 8).

6. “How long before you will judge and avenge our blood on those who dwell on the earth?” (v. 10).

7. “Told to rest a little longer, until the number of their fellow servants and their brothers should be complete” (v. 11).

8. “For the great day of their wrath has come, and who can stand?” (v. 17).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The first four seals are four horsemen. Each is summoned by one of the living creatures: “Come!” The first, on a white horse, has a bow and a crown and “came out conquering, and to conquer.” Interpreters disagree about the rider. Some see Christ (compare 19:11, where Christ rides a white horse), or the gospel going out in conquest. Others see a counterfeit, the spirit of military conquest, because the horsemen that follow are all evils. The second, on a red horse, takes peace from the earth so that people slay one another, with a great sword: war and violence. The third, on a black horse, holds a balance. A quart of wheat for a denarius, a day’s wage, means famine prices: a worker could buy only enough for himself, with nothing for his family. But the oil and wine are not harmed, as though a limit were set on the famine. The fourth, on a pale horse, is Death, with Hades following, “given authority over a fourth of the earth, to kill with sword and with famine and with pestilence and by wild beasts.” Notice the repeated “it was given”: they have authority only as far as God permits.

The fifth seal moves from the earth to the altar in heaven. John sees “the souls of those who had been slain for the word of God and for the witness they had borne.” They cry out, “O Sovereign Lord, holy and true, how long before you will judge and avenge our blood on those who dwell on the earth?” This is the cry of every martyr and every victim of injustice, and God hears it. It is not a request for private revenge but for God’s justice to be shown. Each is given a white robe and told “to rest a little longer, until the number of their fellow servants and their brothers should be complete, who were to be killed as they themselves had been.” God has a plan and a timetable, and the suffering of his people is part of it.

The sixth seal brings cosmic upheaval: a great earthquake, the sun black as sackcloth, the moon like blood, stars falling, the sky vanishing, every mountain and island moved. This is the language that the prophets used for the day of the Lord. Everyone, kings, great ones, rich, strong, slave and free, hides in caves and calls on the mountains and rocks, “Fall on us and hide us from the face of him who is seated on the throne, and from the wrath of the Lamb, for the great day of their wrath has come, and who can stand?” The Lamb, who is gentle, is also the judge. The wrath of the Lamb is the final answer to the cry of the martyrs.

The chapter ends with a question that the next chapter answers: “Who can stand?” The answer is those who are sealed by God (chapter 7). Until then, the church lives in an age of war, famine, death, and persecution, and the Lamb is on the throne.

STEP 5

## Connection

Zechariah 1:7-11 and 6:1-8 are the sources for the horsemen. Matthew 24:4-14 describes the same pattern of conquest, wars, famines, and persecution. Ezekiel 14:21 mentions four judgments. Genesis 4:10 speaks of the blood that cries out. Psalm 79:5, 13:1-2, and Habakkuk 1:2 ask “how long?” Luke 18:7-8 promises justice for those who cry to God. Isaiah 13:10, 34:4, and Joel 2:30-31 use cosmic language. Hosea 10:8 and Luke 23:30 describe calling on mountains. Malachi 3:2 asks who can stand. Romans 12:19 says vengeance belongs to the Lord.

STEP 6

## Application

When news of wars, famines, and disasters weighs on you, remember that each seal is opened by the Lamb. He is not surprised.

Pray for persecuted Christians around the world, using the martyrs’ cry, “how long?”

Think about your readiness to stand before God. Thank Christ that the one who judges is the one who died for you.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Thank Jesus that nothing happens in history outside his authority.
- Tell him what makes you afraid about the state of the world.
- Ask him to give you patience while you wait.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 125

“Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!”

REVELATION 5:12

DAY 875 · WEEK 125

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Revelation 5:12 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"Worthy is the Lamb who was slain, to receive power and wealth and wisdom and might and honor and glory and blessing!"

REVELATION 5:12

REST

## Meditation

Count the attributes in this one verse: power, wealth, wisdom, might, honor, glory, blessing. Seven, the number of completeness. Everything good that anyone could give to anyone is given to the Lamb. And he is worthy, not because of what he has but because of what he did: he was slain.

Think about who the Lamb is. He is the Son of God, and he took on flesh, bore the sins of the world, and was killed. Heaven's greatest worship is for the one who was slaughtered. This reveals what God values. Not conquest by force, but love poured out. Worth is measured at the cross.

This verse can be sung in the car, whispered in a hospital, or shouted at a graveside. When your worth is questioned, or when you feel powerless, remember that the worthy one died for you. Say it aloud, and add your voice to the angels' choir.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week you read the letters to the churches and the opening of the seals. Revelation 3 gave Jesus' words to Sardis (alive in name only), Philadelphia (faithful with little power, given an open door), and Laodicea (lukewarm and self-satisfied, with Christ knocking at the door). Three psalms reflected on the way of the blessed (Psalm 1), the glory of creation and the word (Psalm 19), and the voice of the LORD in the storm (Psalm 29). Revelation 4 and 5 brought us into the throne room, with the worship of the Creator and the Lion who is a Lamb, worthy to open the scroll because he was slain and ransomed people from every nation. Revelation 6 showed the Lamb opening six seals: conquest, war, famine, death, the cry of the martyrs, and the wrath of the Lamb, ending with the question, "who can stand?"

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

Jesus tells Laodicea, "Behold, I stand at the door and knock." Is there an area where you have been keeping him outside? What would it look like to open the door today?

John expected a Lion and saw a Lamb. How does the way Jesus won, through sacrifice, change the way you think about strength, success, and winning?

The martyrs cry, "How long?" and are told to rest a little longer. What are you waiting on God for? How can you trust that he hears?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Worship the Lamb who was slain.

Thank him that he holds the scroll of history.

Rest in his hand.

DAY 876 · WEEK 126

# Revelation 7:1-8:13

*The 144,000 and the great multitude; the seventh seal*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 30 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 7:1-8:13. Chapter 7 is an interlude between the sixth and seventh seals, answering the question "who can stand?" Chapter 8 opens the seventh seal and introduces the first trumpets. Notice the contrast between what John hears and what he sees.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

At the close of chapter 6, the world cries out, "who can stand?" Chapter 7 answers: the servants of God who are sealed. Like the pause in a symphony before the finale, this chapter shows the security of God's people before the next round of judgments. It is also one of the most debated chapters in the book, because of the identity of the 144,000. Readers should note the pattern John uses elsewhere: he hears one thing and sees another (the Lion and the Lamb in chapter 5), so that the two parts interpret each other.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Do not harm the earth or the sea or the trees, until we have sealed the servants of our God on their foreheads" (7:3).
2. "And I heard the number of the sealed, 144,000, sealed from every tribe of the sons of Israel" (7:4).
3. "A great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb" (7:9).
4. "Salvation belongs to our God who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb!" (7:10).
5. "They have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb" (7:14).

6. “For the Lamb in the midst of the throne will be their shepherd, and he will guide them to springs of living water” (7:17).
7. “When the Lamb opened the seventh seal, there was silence in heaven for about half an hour” (8:1).
8. “The smoke of the incense, with the prayers of the saints, rose before God from the hand of the angel” (8:4).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Four angels stand at the four corners of the earth, holding back the four winds. Another angel with the seal of the living God cries out, “Do not harm the earth or the sea or the trees, until we have sealed the servants of our God on their foreheads.” The seal marks ownership and protection, the opposite of the mark of the beast later. Then John hears the number: 144,000, twelve thousand from each of the twelve tribes of Israel (with Dan omitted and Manasseh included in the list).

Who are they? Christians have given different answers. Some, especially dispensational interpreters, believe they are ethnic Israelites, perhaps converted Jews in a future tribulation. Others believe they are the church, the new Israel, the whole people of God described in the language of the old covenant, which the New Testament elsewhere applies to the church (Galatians 6:16; James 1:1; 1 Peter 1:1; Revelation 21:12-14). The number is twelve times twelve times a thousand, a symbol of completeness. The tribes are listed as an army ready for battle (Numbers 1-2), the sealed ones.

The next scene supports the second reading. “After this I looked, and behold, a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb, clothed in white robes, with palm branches in their hands.” As in chapter 5, John hears a number (the 144,000) and then sees a multitude beyond number. This echoes God’s promise to Abraham of descendants like the stars (Genesis 15:5; 22:17). It is the same people seen from two angles: Israel as an ordered army and the nations as a countless crowd. The multitude cries, “Salvation belongs to our God who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb!” and the angels, elders, and creatures respond with a sevenfold doxology.

An elder asks, “Who are these, clothed in white robes, and from where have they come?” And answers: “These are the ones coming out of the great tribulation. They have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb.” This is a paradox: robes washed in blood become white. The great tribulation is understood by some as a future period at the end of the age, and by others as the whole age of the church’s suffering. Either way, those who endure are cleansed only by the blood of Christ. Their destiny is beautiful: “Therefore

they are before the throne of God, and serve him day and night in his temple; and he who sits on the throne will shelter them with his presence. They shall hunger no more, neither thirst anymore… For the Lamb in the midst of the throne will be their shepherd, and he will guide them to springs of living water, and God will wipe away every tear from their eyes." The Lamb is a shepherd, another paradox.

Chapter 8 opens the seventh seal. The result is silence: "there was silence in heaven for about half an hour." After the praise, a hush before the final events. Then seven angels are given seven trumpets. Another angel stands at the golden altar with a censer and "much incense to offer with the prayers of all the saints." The smoke of the incense, with the prayers of the saints, rises before God. Then the angel fills the censer with fire from the altar and throws it on the earth: thunder, lightning, earthquake. The prayers of the saints (like the martyrs' cry in 6:10) are answered with judgment. The first four trumpets echo the plagues of Egypt: hail and fire mixed with blood burning a third of the earth; a burning mountain thrown into the sea; a star called Wormwood poisoning a third of the waters; a third of the sun, moon, and stars struck. These judgments are partial (a third), warnings meant to lead to repentance. An eagle flying overhead cries, "Woe, woe, woe to those who dwell on the earth," for three more trumpets remain.

STEP 5

## Connection

Ezekiel 9:4-6 and 2 Corinthians 1:22 speak of God's seal. Ephesians 1:13 and 4:30 say believers are sealed with the Holy Spirit. Genesis 12:3, 15:5, and Romans 4:16-18 speak of Abraham's multitude. Galatians 3:7-9, 29 and 6:16 call believers the Israel of God and Abraham's offspring. Leviticus 23:40-43 and John 12:13 mention palm branches. Daniel 12:1 and Matthew 24:21 speak of great tribulation. Isaiah 25:8 and 49:10 are echoed in 7:16-17. Psalm 23:1-2 and John 10:11 show the shepherd. Habakkuk 2:20 calls for silence before the LORD. Exodus 7-10 recounts the plagues. Psalm 141:2 speaks of prayer as incense.

STEP 6

## Application

Place yourself in the great multitude. Read 7:9-17 slowly, and thank Christ for washing your robes in his blood.

When you face a trial, recall verse 17: the Lamb is your shepherd, and he will wipe away every tear.

Pray with the confidence that your prayers rise before God like incense and are not lost.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank Jesus for sealing and keeping his servants.

Thank him for a people from every nation.

Ask him to keep you faithful through tribulation.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 126

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."

REVELATION 12:11

DAY 877 · WEEK 126

# Revelation 9:1-11:19

*The trumpets; the two witnesses; the kingdom proclaimed*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 80 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 9:1-11:19. This is a long and demanding reading with the fifth and sixth trumpets, the little scroll, the two witnesses, and the seventh trumpet. Read it as a story of judgment, witness, and the arrival of the kingdom, and watch for its connection to Daniel, Ezekiel, and Zechariah.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The trumpets sound a series of judgments that echo the plagues of Egypt, with the first four affecting nature (chapter 8) and the next three, called "woes," affecting humanity. As with the seals, the trumpets are divided into six, followed by an interlude (10:1-11:14), and then a seventh. The interlude shows the church's role in this period: John eats a little scroll and the church prophesies as two witnesses. The seventh trumpet brings the announcement that the kingdom has come.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "I saw a star fallen from heaven to earth, and he was given the key to the shaft of the bottomless pit" (9:1).
2. "Did not repent of the works of their hands" (9:20).
3. "In the days of the trumpet call to be sounded by the seventh angel, the mystery of God would be fulfilled, just as he announced to his servants the prophets" (10:7).
4. "It was sweet as honey in my mouth, but when I had eaten it my stomach was made bitter" (10:10).
5. "And I will grant authority to my two witnesses, and they will prophesy for 1,260 days, clothed in sackcloth" (11:3).

6. “But after the three and a half days a breath of life from God entered them, and they stood up on their feet” (11:11).
7. “The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ, and he shall reign forever and ever” (11:15).
8. “The ark of his covenant was seen within his temple” (11:19).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The fifth trumpet brings a star fallen from heaven, given the key to the shaft of the bottomless pit. Smoke rises, and out of the smoke come locusts with power like scorpions. They are told not to harm the grass but only people who do not have the seal of God on their foreheads, torturing them for five months. Their king is the angel of the bottomless pit, Abaddon or Apollyon, the Destroyer. This is a picture of demonic torment let loose on unbelievers, limited in extent and duration. The sixth trumpet releases four angels bound at the Euphrates, with an army of 200 million horsemen whose horses have heads like lions and tails like serpents. A third of mankind is killed. Yet the rest “did not repent of the works of their hands nor give up worshiping demons and idols,” nor repent of murders, sorceries, sexual immorality, or thefts. This is the tragedy of the passage: judgment does not by itself change hearts.

Then comes an interlude. A mighty angel, wrapped in a cloud with a rainbow over his head and a face like the sun, with feet like pillars of fire, stands with one foot on the sea and one on the land, holding a little scroll open in his hand. Seven thunders speak, but John is told to seal up what they said. The angel swears by the Creator that there will be no more delay: “in the days of the trumpet call to be sounded by the seventh angel, the mystery of God would be fulfilled, just as he announced to his servants the prophets.” John is told to eat the little scroll, as Ezekiel did (Ezekiel 3:1-3). “It was sweet as honey in my mouth, but when I had eaten it my stomach was made bitter.” The word of God is sweet to receive and bitter to deliver, because it includes judgment and suffering. He must prophesy again about many peoples, nations, languages, and kings.

Chapter 11 begins with John measuring the temple of God and the altar and those who worship there, but not the outer court, which is given over to the nations, who will trample the holy city for forty-two months. The measuring is a picture of God’s protection of his people (the true temple, understood by many as the church) while the world persecutes them. The forty-two months (also 1,260 days or “a time, times, and half a time” from Daniel 7:25) is a symbolic period of limited, intense testing. During this time, God grants authority to “my two witnesses.” They prophesy in sackcloth. They are described as two olive trees and two lampstands (Zechariah 4), with power like Moses and Elijah, to shut the sky and strike

the earth with plagues. Interpreters disagree about who they are: two literal prophets in the end times, or, as many hold, the church in its witnessing role, the two representing the legal requirement of two witnesses (Deuteronomy 19:15). When they finish their testimony, the beast from the bottomless pit kills them, and their bodies lie in the street of the great city "where their Lord was crucified," while the world gloats and exchanges gifts. But "after the three and a half days a breath of life from God entered them, and they stood up on their feet, and great fear fell on those who saw them." They are called up to heaven in a cloud. The witnessing church may seem defeated, but it will be vindicated.

The seventh trumpet brings loud voices in heaven: "The kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord and of his Christ, and he shall reign forever and ever." The elders fall on their faces: "We give thanks to you, Lord God Almighty, who is and who was, for you have taken your great power and begun to reign. The nations raged, but your wrath came, and the time for the dead to be judged, and for rewarding your servants." The tense is almost past: the victory is announced as accomplished. The chapter closes with the opening of God's temple in heaven and the sight of the ark of his covenant, with flashes of lightning, rumblings, thunder, an earthquake, and heavy hail. The ark signifies God's covenant faithfulness; he keeps his promises, and the covenant community is secure.

STEP 5

## Connection

Exodus 7-10 and Joel 1-2 are the background of the plagues and locusts. Ezekiel 2:8-3:3 and Jeremiah 15:16 describe eating the scroll. Daniel 7:25, 8:13-14, and 12:7 give the time periods. Zechariah 4:1-14 describes the two olive trees. Deuteronomy 19:15 requires two witnesses. 1 Kings 17:1 and Exodus 7:17-19 relate to the powers of Elijah and Moses. Psalm 2 is the background of 11:15-18. Luke 21:24 mentions Jerusalem trampled. Ephesians 2:19-22 describes the church as God's temple. Hebrews 9:4 mentions the ark of the covenant. Matthew 28:19-20 and Acts 1:8 describe the church's witness.

STEP 6

## Application

Think about the sweet and bitter nature of God's word. What in Scripture is sweet to you, and what is hard to swallow? Receive both.

Consider your role as a witness. Pray that God would give you boldness to speak, even when it is not welcomed.

Read 11:15 aloud as a statement of faith about the future: the kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Tell God what you see of the hardness of the human heart.

Ask him to give you a heart that repents.

Thank him that his judgments are just and the kingdom is his.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 126

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."

REVELATION 12:11

DAY 878 · WEEK 126

# Psalm 141

*Let my prayer be counted as incense*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 10 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 141. It is an evening prayer of David, asking God to hear, to guard the lips, and to keep the heart from evil. Notice the image of prayer as incense and the unusual request to be corrected.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 141 is a psalm of David written in a time of danger, when enemies threatened and temptation pressed. It is a prayer of an individual who feels vulnerable in two ways: to external enemies and to internal temptations. The image of prayer as incense and the lifting of hands as the evening sacrifice would have been strongly associated with the temple. In Revelation, the prayers of the saints are described as incense before the throne (5:8; 8:3-4), and the psalm is the origin of the image.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. “O LORD, I call upon you; hasten to me! Give ear to my voice when I call to you!” (v. 1).
2. “Let my prayer be counted as incense before you, and the lifting up of my hands as the evening sacrifice!” (v. 2).
3. “Set a guard, O LORD, over my mouth; keep watch over the door of my lips!” (v. 3).
4. “Do not let my heart incline to any evil” (v. 4).
5. “Let a righteous man strike me; let it be a kindness; let him rebuke me; it is oil for my head” (v. 5).
6. “But my eyes are toward you, O GOD, my Lord; in you I seek refuge; leave me not defenseless!” (v. 8).

7. “Keep me from the trap that they have laid for me and from the snares of evildoers!” (v. 9).

8. “Let the wicked fall into their own nets, while I pass by safely” (v. 10).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

David starts with urgency: “O LORD, I call upon you; hasten to me!” Then he makes a request that shapes the whole psalm: “Let my prayer be counted as incense before you, and the lifting up of my hands as the evening sacrifice!” In the temple, incense was burned on the golden altar morning and evening, and its fragrant smoke rose up to God. David asks that his prayer would be received as acceptably as the evening incense, though he has no temple at the moment. The same image appears in Revelation 5:8, where the elders hold golden bowls of incense, “which are the prayers of the saints,” and in 8:3-4, where an angel offers much incense with the prayers of all the saints.

Then David turns to his lips and heart, an unexpected request when his enemies are pressing in. “Set a guard, O LORD, over my mouth; keep watch over the door of my lips! Do not let my heart incline to any evil, to busy myself with wicked deeds in company with men who work iniquity; and let me not eat of their delicacies!” He knows that the greater danger is not what enemies do to him but what he might do in anger or temptation. He asks God to guard his speech, his desires, and his company.

Verse 5 is surprising: “Let a righteous man strike me; let it be a kindness; let him rebuke me; it is oil for my head; let my head not refuse it.” He welcomes correction from a faithful friend. Wounds from a friend are faithful (Proverbs 27:6). Those who want to grow in holiness need people who will tell them the truth. This is the opposite of the wicked, who in verse 4 invite him to feast with them, and whose “delicacies” are the pleasures of sin.

The psalm ends with confident refuge. The leaders of the wicked will be thrown down, and their bones scattered at the mouth of Sheol. “But my eyes are toward you, O GOD, my Lord; in you I seek refuge; leave me not defenseless!” He asks to be kept from the trap and snares. “Let the wicked fall into their own nets, while I pass by safely.” In Christ we have the greater sacrifice and intercessor, who ever lives to make intercession for us. Our prayers rise before the throne through his priesthood, and nothing we pray is lost.

STEP 5

## Connection

Exodus 30:1-9 describes the altar of incense. Luke 1:8-10 shows Zechariah offering incense while the people pray outside. Revelation 5:8 and 8:3-4 connect incense and prayer. Proverbs 27:5-6, 9 speaks of rebuke from a friend. Psalm 19:14 and James 3:2-12 pray for guarded

speech. Psalm 119:37 asks for eyes turned from vanity. Matthew 6:13 asks to be led not into temptation. Hebrews 7:25 and Romans 8:34 describe Christ's intercession. Hebrews 13:15 speaks of a sacrifice of praise. Psalm 57:6 and Proverbs 26:27 speak of falling into one's own trap.

STEP 6

## Application

Make this your evening prayer tonight. Lift your hands or bow your head, and offer your prayer as incense.

Ask a trusted friend where they see a blind spot in you. Receive it as "oil for your head."

Pray for a guard over your lips in a specific conversation you will have tomorrow.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Ask God to receive your prayer as incense.

Ask him to guard your mouth and your heart.

Thank him that he hears the cry of the afflicted.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 126

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."

REVELATION 12:11

DAY 879 · WEEK 126

# Psalm 150

*Praise him with trumpet and harp*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 150. It is the last psalm of the Psalter, a burst of praise with trumpet and harp. Notice where, why, how, and who: the psalm answers each of these questions in six short verses.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 150 is the final psalm of the five books of Psalms, a doxology that closes the whole collection with an explosion of praise. Every verse is a command to praise, and the word "praise" occurs thirteen times in six verses. Today we read it with the trumpets of Revelation in mind: in Israel, trumpets were sounded for both worship and war, and in Revelation, trumpet blasts announce judgment, but they end with the loudest praise of all (11:15). We will read it again at the end of the book, where we will see it as a closing word of the whole Bible.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Praise God in his sanctuary; praise him in his mighty heavens!" (v. 1).
2. "Praise him for his mighty deeds" (v. 2).
3. "Praise him according to his excellent greatness!" (v. 2).
4. "Praise him with trumpet sound; praise him with lute and harp!" (v. 3).
5. "Praise him with tambourine and dance; praise him with strings and pipe!" (v. 4).
6. "Praise him with sounding cymbals; praise him with loud clashing cymbals!" (v. 5).
7. "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD!" (v. 6).
8. "Praise the LORD!" (v. 6).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm answers four questions. Where should we praise? “In his sanctuary” and “in his mighty heavens”: on earth in the place of worship and in heaven, everywhere. Why? “For his mighty deeds” and “according to his excellent greatness.” We praise him for what he has done (creation, redemption, deliverance) and for who he is. How? With every instrument they knew. “Praise him with trumpet sound; praise him with lute and harp! Praise him with tambourine and dance; praise him with strings and pipe! Praise him with sounding cymbals; praise him with loud clashing cymbals!” This includes wind, strings, and percussion, with dance and with the whole body. True worship is not limited to one style or mood; it engages every part of life. Who? “Let everything that has breath praise the LORD!” Every living creature has breath from God, and so all should return it in praise.

This psalm comes at the end of a book that is full of laments, confessions, complaints, and questions. After all of that, the book ends in praise. It tells us that praise is the destination of the life of faith. When we reach the end of the road, everything we have prayed about will have led to this.

Now, read it with Revelation. In the book, the trumpets of Revelation 8 and 9 are sounded by angels as judgment on a rebellious world. But the seventh trumpet in 11:15 brings a different sound: loud voices in heaven proclaiming that the kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord. And in 14:2 and 15:2, the harps of God accompany the song of the redeemed. The trumpets that announce judgment lead to praise because the Judge is also the Redeemer. The final victory means that the cries of the oppressed and the praise of God’s people fill the universe.

Notice also the order: God is praised in his sanctuary, and in his heavens. The two meet in the book of Revelation, where the heavenly worship is opened up to the earthly church, and where the new Jerusalem comes down out of heaven. One day there will be no separation: all of creation will join the song. Until then, we praise by faith.

STEP 5

## Connection

1 Chronicles 15:16-28 and 2 Chronicles 5:11-14 describe temple music. Numbers 10:1-10 and Joshua 6 describe trumpets in worship and war. Exodus 15:20-21 shows Miriam with tambourines. 2 Samuel 6:14-15 shows David dancing before the LORD. Psalm 98:4-6 also calls for trumpets and harps. Revelation 5:8-14, 11:15-18, 14:2-3, and 15:2-4 describe heavenly worship. Colossians 3:16 and Ephesians 5:19 call for singing in the church. Psalm 148 and 149 are the other closing psalms of praise. Hebrews 13:15 calls for a sacrifice of praise.

STEP 6

## Application

Praise God out loud today, with music if you can. Use a hymn or a worship song that expresses his greatness.

Ask which of the four questions (where, why, how, who) you need to grow in: praising in more places, for more reasons, with more of your body, or inviting more people.

Notice when you take a breath today, and let each be a reminder to praise the LORD.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Praise God in his sanctuary and in his mighty heavens, in your own words.

Praise him for his mighty deeds.

Let everything that has breath praise him, and add your own.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 126

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."

REVELATION 12:11

DAY 880 · WEEK 126

# Psalm 148

*Praise the LORD from the heavens*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 14 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 148. This psalm calls the whole creation to praise, from the angels to the sea monsters to kings and children. Notice the two halves: praise from the heavens (vv. 1-6) and praise from the earth (vv. 7-14).

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 148 is one of the Hallel psalms at the end of the Psalter (146 to 150). It is a hymn calling all of creation to praise the LORD. It has no named author, and it does not tell a story but sings an invitation. It prepares us for the last two weeks of Revelation, where every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and in the sea joins in worship (5:13). Today we will see the whole creation as a choir, with Christ as the horn that God has raised up.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. “Praise the LORD! Praise the LORD from the heavens; praise him in the heights!” (v. 1).
2. “Praise him, all his angels; praise him, all his hosts!” (v. 2).
3. “Praise him, sun and moon, praise him, all you shining stars!” (v. 3).
4. “Let them praise the name of the LORD! For he commanded and they were created” (v. 5).
5. “Praise the LORD from the earth, you great sea creatures and all deeps” (v. 7).
6. “Kings of the earth and all peoples, princes and all rulers of the earth!” (v. 11).
7. “Let them praise the name of the LORD, for his name alone is exalted” (v. 13).
8. “He has raised up a horn for his people, praise for all his saints” (v. 14).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm starts above: “Praise the LORD from the heavens; praise him in the heights!” The angels and hosts, the sun and moon and stars, the highest heavens and the waters above the heavens are told to praise. The reason is given: “Let them praise the name of the LORD! For he commanded and they were created. And he established them forever and ever; he gave a decree, and it shall not pass away.” Creation praises by being what God made it to be, obeying his command. The heavens do not need words to praise him; their ordered existence proclaims his wisdom.

The second half comes down to the earth. “Praise the LORD from the earth, you great sea creatures and all deeps, fire and hail, snow and mist, stormy wind fulfilling his word! Mountains and all hills, fruit trees and all cedars! Beasts and all livestock, creeping things and flying birds!” The psalmist lists everything: sea monsters (which in other cultures were symbols of chaos and are here put in their place), weather, mountains, trees, animals. Then humanity: “Kings of the earth and all peoples, princes and all rulers of the earth! Young men and maidens together, old men and children!” The call goes from rulers to children, with no one left out. It includes every age and every rank.

The reason for human praise is the same: “Let them praise the name of the LORD, for his name alone is exalted; his majesty is above earth and heaven.” And then the psalm gives a particular reason for the people of God to praise: “He has raised up a horn for his people, praise for all his saints, for the people of Israel who are near to him.” A horn is a symbol of strength and, in this context, a ruler or savior from the house of David. Zechariah, in Luke 1:69, uses the same image for Jesus: “He has raised up a horn of salvation for us in the house of his servant David.” The creation praises its Maker, and the church praises the one who has saved it.

This psalm gives dignity to everything in creation, a reminder that the world is a stage for God’s glory. It also shows that our praise is part of something bigger. When we sing, we join the sun, the stars, the sea creatures, the trees, and the angels. And in Revelation 5:13, John hears “every creature in heaven and on earth and under the earth and in the sea, and all that is in them, saying, To him who sits on the throne and to the Lamb be blessing and honor and glory and might forever and ever!” Psalm 148 is the first draft of that chorus.

STEP 5

## Connection

Genesis 1 recounts the creation that Psalm 148 praises. Psalm 19:1-4 and 96:11-13 also have creation praising God. Isaiah 55:12 has trees clapping their hands. Job 38-41 shows the Creator’s care for the whole creation. Luke 1:69 uses the horn for Christ. Psalm 132:17 speaks

of a horn for David. Romans 8:19-23 describes creation waiting for redemption. Colossians 1:16-20 describes all things created through and reconciled to Christ. Revelation 5:13 and 21:1-5 show all creation worshiping. Philippians 2:10-11 describes every knee bowing.

STEP 6

## Application

Take a walk outside and notice one thing from each group in the psalm: the sky, the weather, a plant, an animal. Let each prompt a short prayer of praise.

Think about the whole range of ages and ranks in your church. Ask how you can include someone from a different age or background in worship.

Thank Christ for being the horn that God has raised up for his people.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Praise God from the heavens and from the earth.
- Add your voice to the voices of angels and creation.
- Tell him what in creation moves you to praise.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 126

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."

REVELATION 12:11

DAY 881 · WEEK 126

# Revelation 12:1-13:18

*The woman and the dragon; the two beasts*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 35 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 12:1-13:18. This is among the most symbolic parts of the book. Read it as a drama in three parts: the woman and the dragon, the war in heaven, and the two beasts who serve the dragon. Notice the repeated pattern of the dragon's power and the saints' victory.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

After the seventh trumpet, the book moves to a second half, which looks at the spiritual conflict behind history. John is shown the "great sign" of a woman and a dragon, then the beasts. These are not simply events to come but pictures of realities that have been present since the fall: Satan's enmity against the offspring of the woman (Genesis 3:15), the state's tendency to demand worship (Daniel 3 and 7), and the false religion that serves it. For first-century Christians under Rome, the beast from the sea was plainly the empire and its emperors, and the beast from the land was the priesthood and propaganda of the imperial cult. For us, these chapters expose similar powers in every age, and may point to a final climax of their rebellion.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Behold, a great red dragon, with seven heads and ten horns" (12:3).
2. "One who is to rule all the nations with a rod of iron" (12:5).
3. "That ancient serpent, who is called the devil and Satan, the deceiver of the whole world" (12:9).
4. "They have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony" (12:11).

5. “He knows that his time is short” (12:12).
6. “A beast rising out of the sea, with ten horns and seven heads” (13:1).
7. “The book of life of the Lamb who was slain” (13:8).
8. “Here is a call for the endurance and faith of the saints” (13:10).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

A great sign appears in heaven: a woman clothed with the sun, with the moon under her feet and a crown of twelve stars, about to give birth. She represents the people of God, from whom the Messiah comes: Israel in the Old Testament, and the church in the New (some also see Mary as the model). A great red dragon stands before her, with seven heads, ten horns, and seven diadems, ready to devour her child. His tail sweeps down a third of the stars (fallen angels). The child is born, “a male child, one who is to rule all the nations with a rod of iron” (Psalm 2:9), and is caught up to God and to his throne. This compresses the life of Christ: his birth, his rule, and his ascension, with the cross implied. The woman flees into the wilderness, where she is nourished for 1,260 days.

Then war breaks out in heaven. Michael and his angels fight the dragon, and “the great dragon was thrown down, that ancient serpent, who is called the devil and Satan, the deceiver of the whole world.” He is identified fully: the serpent of Genesis 3, the accuser. A loud voice proclaims: “Now the salvation and the power and the kingdom of our God and the authority of his Christ have come, for the accuser of our brothers has been thrown down.” Many see this as the effect of Christ’s death and ascension, when Satan’s accusing power was broken. And the means of victory: “And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death.” The church wins not by force but by the blood of Christ, faithful witness, and willingness to die. But “woe to you, O earth and sea, for the devil has come down to you in great wrath, because he knows that his time is short!” A defeated enemy is the most dangerous; he turns to persecute the woman and the rest of her offspring, “those who keep the commandments of God and hold to the testimony of Jesus.”

Chapter 13 introduces the dragon’s two agents. The first beast rises out of the sea with ten horns, seven heads, and blasphemous names. It resembles Daniel’s four beasts combined. The dragon gives it his power and throne and great authority. One of its heads seems to have a mortal wound that is healed (a parody of the resurrection). The whole earth marvels and worships the dragon and the beast: “Who is like the beast, and who can fight against it?” This mocks the praise of God, “Who is like you, O LORD?” It is allowed for forty-two months to utter blasphemies and “to make war on the saints and to conquer them.” All will worship it,

“everyone whose name has not been written before the foundation of the world in the book of life of the Lamb who was slain.” And in the middle comes a call for the saints: “Here is a call for the endurance and faith of the saints.”

The second beast rises out of the earth, with two horns like a lamb but speaking like a dragon. It exercises the authority of the first beast and makes the earth worship it, performing signs and deceiving the inhabitants. It orders an image of the beast and causes all to be marked on the right hand or forehead, “so that no one can buy or sell unless he has the mark, that is, the name of the beast or the number of its name.” It is a parody of the Spirit, as the first beast is a parody of Christ. The number is given: “This calls for wisdom: let the one who has understanding calculate the number of the beast, for it is the number of a man, and his number is 666.” Many early Christians understood this by the Hebrew letters as pointing to Nero Caesar; others see it as a symbol of human imperfection (falling short of seven, repeated three times); others as a future individual. In every approach, the lesson is the same: the world powers that demand ultimate loyalty are in the service of the dragon, but they are allowed only a limited time, and the Lamb’s book of life cannot be erased.

STEP 5

## Connection

Genesis 3:15 is the first promise of the woman’s offspring and the serpent. Isaiah 66:7-9 and Micah 5:2-3 mention the birth of the Messiah. Psalm 2:9 is quoted in 12:5. Daniel 7:2-8 describes four beasts rising from the sea. Daniel 3 tells of the demand to worship an image. Job 1-2 and Zechariah 3:1-2 show Satan as accuser. Romans 8:33-34 answers the accuser. Luke 10:18 and John 12:31 describe Satan’s fall and judgment. 2 Thessalonians 2:3-12 describes the man of lawlessness. 1 John 2:18 and 4:3 speak of antichrists. Matthew 24:24 mentions false signs. Exodus 15:11 and Psalm 35:10 ask, “Who is like you?”

STEP 6

## Application

When you feel overwhelmed by evil, remember how the saints conquer: by the blood of the Lamb, the word of their testimony, and not loving their lives even unto death.

Examine where the world’s powers ask for your ultimate loyalty (nation, money, ideology, security). Choose one area where you need to worship only the Lamb.

Pray for Christians who are living under regimes that demand allegiance contrary to Christ.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank Jesus for being the child who rules the nations.

Thank him that the accuser is conquered by his blood.

Ask him for courage to speak your testimony.

**MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 126**

“And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death.”

**REVELATION 12:11**

DAY 882 · WEEK 126

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Revelation 12:11 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"And they have conquered him by the blood of the Lamb and by the word of their testimony, for they loved not their lives even unto death."

REVELATION 12:11

REST

## Meditation

This verse holds the secret of the Christian's victory over Satan. It has three parts.

First, "the blood of the Lamb." This is the ground of our victory. The accuser has charges against us, but the blood answers every charge. We do not defeat him with our own righteousness but with Christ's sacrifice, which has already paid the price.

Second, "the word of their testimony." This is the means. Christians speak the truth about Jesus, about what he has done and who he is, in the face of the lie. Testimony is not only for the pulpit; it includes the plain way we say what we believe at home, at work, and in suffering.

Third, "they loved not their lives even unto death." This is the cost. Those who are willing to lose their lives for Christ cannot be controlled by fear of death. A person who is not afraid to die cannot be intimidated.

When you feel under spiritual attack, say this verse aloud. Rest in the blood, speak the testimony, and let go of fear.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week you read through the middle of Revelation. Chapter 7 answered the question "who can stand?" with the sealed servants of God and the great multitude from every nation, robes washed in the blood of the Lamb. Chapter 8 opened the seventh seal with silence in heaven, and the prayers of the saints rising as incense before the throne. Chapters 9 to 11 sounded trumpets of judgment, showed the bitter-sweet little scroll, the two witnesses who are killed and raised, and the seventh trumpet announcing that the kingdom of the world has become the kingdom of our Lord. Psalm 141 taught us to pray as incense and to welcome correction. Psalm 150 and Psalm 148 called every creature to praise. Revelation 12 and 13 unveiled the dragon, the woman, and the two beasts, and the church's way of conquering by the blood of the Lamb, the word of testimony, and willingness to die.

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

Revelation 12:11 gives three ways the saints conquered the accuser. Which of these three do you rely on most, and which do you tend to neglect?

Most of the world did not repent despite the trumpets (9:20-21). What does this tell you about the limits of judgment and the need for grace? Who are you praying for who needs a change of heart?

The call of 13:10 is for endurance and faith. What is the hardest area in which you need endurance right now? How can the Lamb's example in Revelation 5 strengthen you?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank Jesus for the victory won by his blood.

Ask him for courage to testify.

Rest in his victory.

DAY 883 · WEEK 127

# Revelation 14:1-15:8

*The 144,000 on Mount Zion; the harvest; the bowls*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 28 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 14:1-15:8. Chapter 14 shows a series of visions of the Lamb and his people, followed by announcements of judgment. Chapter 15 introduces the final seven plagues, with the song of Moses and of the Lamb. Notice the contrast between the Lamb's people on Mount Zion and the world under the beast.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

After the dragon and the beasts, the book gives a series of contrasts to encourage the persecuted church. Where the beast's followers have its mark on their foreheads, the Lamb's followers have his name and his Father's name. These chapters sit between the unveiling of the evil powers and the final outpouring of God's wrath. They announce the fall of Babylon, the final harvest, and the song that celebrates God's justice. Some interpreters see these scenes as parallel to previous ones, returning to the same period from another angle; others see them as moving forward in a chronological sequence.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "On Mount Zion stood the Lamb, and with him 144,000 who had his name and his Father's name written on their foreheads" (14:1).
2. "It is these who follow the Lamb wherever he goes" (14:4).
3. "Another angel flying directly overhead, with an eternal gospel to proclaim to those who dwell on earth, to every nation and tribe and language and people" (14:6).
4. "Fallen, fallen is Babylon the great" (14:8).
5. "Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord from now on" (14:13).

6. “One like a son of man, with a golden crown on his head, and a sharp sickle in his hand” (14:14).
7. “The song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb” (15:3).
8. “All nations will come and worship you, for your righteous acts have been revealed” (15:4).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

John sees the Lamb standing on Mount Zion with the 144,000, who have the name of the Lamb and his Father written on their foreheads. This contrasts with the mark of the beast. A sound from heaven like many waters and loud thunder, and like harpists playing on their harps, accompanies a new song before the throne. The 144,000 are described as those who have not defiled themselves with women (probably a figurative way of saying they have kept themselves pure from the spiritual adultery of idolatry), who “follow the Lamb wherever he goes,” and who were redeemed as firstfruits for God and the Lamb. “In their mouth no lie was found, for they are blameless.” As in chapter 7, they are the whole redeemed people seen as a purified army.

Then three angels. The first flies in midheaven with “an eternal gospel to proclaim to those who dwell on earth, to every nation and tribe and language and people. And he said with a loud voice, Fear God and give him glory, for the hour of his judgment has come, and worship him who made heaven and the earth.” Even in these final scenes, the gospel is proclaimed to every nation. The second angel announces, “Fallen, fallen is Babylon the great,” the first mention of the city that will be described fully in chapters 17 and 18. The third warns that anyone who worships the beast will drink the wine of God’s wrath and be tormented, with no rest day or night. Then a call: “Here is a call for the endurance of the saints, those who keep the commandments of God and their faith in Jesus.” A voice from heaven says, “Blessed are the dead who die in the Lord from now on.” “Blessed indeed,” says the Spirit, “that they may rest from their labors, for their deeds follow them!” This is among the most comforting verses in the book for those who grieve: those who die in Christ are blessed.

Next come two images of harvest. One like a son of man on a white cloud with a sharp sickle reaps the earth’s harvest, which is ripe. An angel then gathers the vintage of the earth and throws it into the great winepress of the wrath of God, and blood flows to a horse’s bridle for 1,600 stadia. These images of judgment are drawn from Joel 3:13 and Isaiah 63:1-6. Interpreters differ on whether the first harvest is the gathering of the righteous (as grain) and the second is the judgment (as grapes), or whether both refer to judgment. What is clear is that the Lord of the harvest has the final say.

Chapter 15 introduces “another sign in heaven, great and amazing: seven angels with seven plagues, which are the last, for with them the wrath of God is finished.” John sees those who had conquered the beast standing beside a sea of glass mingled with fire, with harps of God in their hands. They sing “the song of Moses, the servant of God, and the song of the Lamb”: “Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy. All nations will come and worship you, for your righteous acts have been revealed.” Like Israel after the Red Sea (Exodus 15), the redeemed sing on the shore after their deliverance. The song combines the two great redemptions: the exodus and the cross. Then the temple is opened, and the seven angels come out dressed in pure bright linen, and one of the four living creatures gives them seven golden bowls full of God’s wrath. The temple fills with smoke from God’s glory and power, and none can enter until the plagues are completed.

STEP 5

## Connection

Joel 3:13 and Isaiah 63:1-6 are the images of harvest and winepress. Exodus 15:1-18 is the song of Moses. Deuteronomy 32 is another song of Moses. Psalm 86:9-10 and 98:1-3 speak of the nations worshiping. Isaiah 21:9 and Jeremiah 51:8 announce the fall of Babylon. Matthew 13:24-43 describes the harvest at the end of the age. Matthew 24:14 says the gospel will be preached to all nations. Hebrews 4:9-11 speaks of rest. 1 Corinthians 15:58 says our labor is not in vain. Exodus 40:34-35 and 1 Kings 8:10-11 show the glory filling the temple.

STEP 6

## Application

Remember, when you grieve a believer who has died, that their deeds follow them and they rest from their labors (14:13).

Ask whom you can tell the “eternal gospel,” and pray for opportunity this week.

Sing a song of deliverance today, and use the words of 15:3-4.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Praise God that great and amazing are his deeds.

Ask him to give you a heart that fears and glorifies him.

Thank him for those who endure.

**MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 127**

“Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy.”

**REVELATION 15:3-4**

DAY 884 · WEEK 127

# Psalm 2

*Why do the nations rage?*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 2. It is one of the royal psalms, quoted again and again in the New Testament. Read it as four scenes: the nations rebel (vv. 1-3), God laughs (vv. 4-6), the Son speaks (vv. 7-9), and the kings are warned (vv. 10-12).

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 2 was probably used at the coronation of a king in David's line, when surrounding nations might revolt against a new ruler. But its language is too large for any ordinary Israelite king: the Lord's anointed is called God's Son and given the nations as his inheritance. The New Testament sees its fulfillment in Jesus. Early Christians prayed it in Acts 4 when persecuted. Revelation draws on it repeatedly (2:26-27; 11:15-18; 12:5; 19:15), so it is one of the keys to the book.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain?" (v. 1).
2. "The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the LORD and against his anointed" (v. 2).
3. "He who sits in the heavens laughs" (v. 4).
4. "As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill" (v. 6).
5. "You are my Son; today I have begotten you" (v. 7).
6. "Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession" (v. 8).
7. "Serve the LORD with fear, and rejoice with trembling" (v. 11).

8 “Blessed are all who take refuge in him” (v. 12).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm begins with a question of astonishment: “Why do the nations rage and the peoples plot in vain?” It is a futile revolt. “The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the LORD and against his anointed, saying, Let us burst their bonds apart and cast away their cords from us.” They think of God’s rule as a prison. The picture is one of the whole world, with its political powers, in rebellion against God and his Messiah. This is exactly the setting of Revelation: the dragon, the beasts, and the kings of the earth raging against the Lamb.

Then God’s response: “He who sits in the heavens laughs; the Lord holds them in derision.” It is not a happy laugh but the laughter of one who sees that the attempt is hopeless. Then he speaks to them in his wrath: “As for me, I have set my King on Zion, my holy hill.” The rebels cannot undo what God has done.

The King himself speaks next: “I will tell of the decree: The LORD said to me, You are my Son; today I have begotten you.” This is the promise to David (2 Samuel 7:14) and finds its ultimate fulfillment in Jesus, whom the New Testament declares to be the Son at his baptism, transfiguration, and resurrection (Acts 13:33; Romans 1:4; Hebrews 1:5). “Ask of me, and I will make the nations your heritage, and the ends of the earth your possession. You shall break them with a rod of iron and dash them in pieces like a potter’s vessel.” Revelation takes this promise and applies it to Christ and to those who share his rule (2:26-27; 12:5; 19:15). This does not mean we have violent power; it means that his kingdom will conquer all that opposes it.

Finally, a warning with an invitation: “Now therefore, O kings, be wise; be warned, O rulers of the earth. Serve the LORD with fear, and rejoice with trembling. Kiss the Son, lest he be angry, and you perish in the way, for his wrath is quickly kindled. Blessed are all who take refuge in him.” To kiss the Son is to submit to him and to honor him. The psalm began with the first Psalm’s word for the blessed man and ends with the same word for all who take refuge in the Son. There is a way out of judgment: take refuge in him. The same Son who will judge the nations invites us into his shelter. And so the great conflict of Revelation is not a conflict between equal powers: it is between a rebellious world and the King whom God has installed.

STEP 5

## Connection

2 Samuel 7:12-16 is the promise to David. Acts 4:23-31 quotes the psalm in prayer. Acts 13:32-33, Hebrews 1:5, and 5:5 quote verse 7. Matthew 3:17 and 17:5 echo it at Jesus' baptism and transfiguration. Revelation 2:26-27, 11:15-18, 12:5, 19:15 draw on it. Philippians 2:9-11 describes the nations bowing to Jesus. Ephesians 1:20-22 speaks of his rule. Psalm 110:1-2 speaks of his enemies as his footstool. Psalm 1:1 and 2:12 frame the opening of the Psalter with "blessed." John 3:36 warns about the Son's wrath.

STEP 6

## Application

When news about the nations is discouraging, say verse 4 to yourself. God is not anxious.

Take refuge in the Son today by naming something you fear and entrusting it to Christ.

Pray for rulers by name, that they would kiss the Son and be wise.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Tell God what raging and plotting you see.
- Thank him for the Son he has set on Zion.
- Take refuge in the Son.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 127

"Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy."

REVELATION 15:3-4

DAY 885 · WEEK 127

# Psalm 46

*God is our refuge*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 46. It is the psalm behind Martin Luther's hymn "A Mighty Fortress." Notice the three stanzas separated by "Selah," each ending in the refrain, "The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress."

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 46 is a song of the sons of Korah, probably written after a great deliverance, perhaps the rescue of Jerusalem from Sennacherib's army in 701 BC (Isaiah 36-37). It sets the stability of God's city against the chaos of earthquakes and storms and the raging of nations. In our reading of Revelation, it provides a counterpoint to the plagues and wars: in the middle of upheaval, the people of God have a river, a city, and a God who is present.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble" (v. 1).
2. "Therefore we will not fear though the earth gives way" (v. 2).
3. "There is a river whose streams make glad the city of God" (v. 4).
4. "God is in the midst of her; she shall not be moved; God will help her when morning dawns" (v. 5).
5. "The nations rage, the kingdoms totter; he utters his voice, the earth melts" (v. 6).
6. "The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress" (v. 7).
7. "He makes wars cease to the end of the earth" (v. 9).
8. "Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted in the earth!" (v. 10).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm opens with a statement of faith: “God is our refuge and strength, a very present help in trouble.” He is not a distant helper; he is very present, close at hand. The consequence is: “Therefore we will not fear though the earth gives way, though the mountains be moved into the heart of the sea, though its waters roar and foam, though the mountains tremble at its swelling.” This is the worst-case scenario: creation itself coming apart. Even then, God’s people do not fear. It is like many of the images in Revelation, where mountains move and seas turn to blood.

The second stanza turns to the city of God. “There is a river whose streams make glad the city of God, the holy habitation of the Most High.” Jerusalem had no river, only a gentle spring, Gihon. The river is symbolic, a picture of God’s presence bringing life and gladness. In Ezekiel 47 and in Revelation 22:1-2, this river becomes a great reality flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb. “God is in the midst of her; she shall not be moved; God will help her when morning dawns.” While the sea roars and mountains shake, the city is safe, because God dwells in it. “The nations rage, the kingdoms totter; he utters his voice, the earth melts.” Notice the same verb used for the nations raging in Psalm 2. Their raging is answered by a word from God.

The third stanza invites us to look at God’s works: “Come, behold the works of the LORD, how he has brought desolations on the earth. He makes wars cease to the end of the earth; he breaks the bow and shatters the spear; he burns the chariots with fire.” The Lord ends wars, which we long to see. And then the famous command: “Be still, and know that I am God. I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted in the earth!” “Be still” means to cease striving, to let go. It is addressed to God’s people in trouble, and also to the raging nations. The way to face the chaos is not to panic but to be still, and know that he is God.

The refrain is the center: “The LORD of hosts is with us; the God of Jacob is our fortress.” The Lord of hosts commands every army, and the God of Jacob is the God who stayed faithful to a flawed man. He is both powerful and personal. And in Christ, he is Immanuel, God with us. At the end of Revelation, the same truth is proclaimed: “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man” (21:3). The city of God, with its river, is the final home of his people.

STEP 5

## Connection

Isaiah 8:8-10 and 37:33-38 relate to Immanuel and the deliverance of Jerusalem. Genesis 2:10-14 and Ezekiel 47:1-12 describe rivers of life. Revelation 21:2-3 and 22:1-2 show the city and river. Psalm 48 and 87 also celebrate the city of God. Psalm 2 uses the same word for nations

raging. Matthew 1:23 gives the name Immanuel. Exodus 14:13-14 shows God fighting for a people who are still. Isaiah 30:15 and 40:31 speak of quietness and strength. Hebrews 12:22-28 speaks of an unshakable kingdom. Romans 8:31-39 expresses similar confidence.

STEP 6

## Application

Take five minutes of silence today, and put a name on the thing you are anxious about. Then say, “Be still, and know that I am God.”

Memorize verse 1. It can be prayed in any trouble.

Name a place in your life where the ground is shaking (health, work, relationships). Place it in the hands of the God who is a very present help.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Tell God what you fear, and say that he is your refuge and strength.

Be still, and know that he is God.

Thank him that he is with you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 127

“Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy.”

REVELATION 15:3-4

DAY 886 · WEEK 127

# Psalm 93

*The LORD reigns; he is robed in majesty*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 93. It is a short psalm that announces the reign of the LORD and speaks of him as mightier than the floods. Read it as a brief hymn that opens a series of enthronement psalms (93, 95-99).

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 93 has no author, but it is one of the "The LORD reigns" psalms. It was probably sung in worship celebrating God's kingship, perhaps at a festival. In the ancient world, floods and seas represented chaos and the forces that threaten order. This psalm declares that the LORD is mightier than all of them. It helps us read Revelation, in which seas, beasts, and floods seem to threaten the people of God, but in which the throne is secure.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "The LORD reigns; he is robed in majesty" (v. 1).
2. "He has put on strength as his belt" (v. 1).
3. "Yes, the world is established; it shall never be moved" (v. 1).
4. "Your throne is established from of old; you are from everlasting" (v. 2).
5. "The floods have lifted up their voice" (v. 3).
6. "Mightier than the thunders of many waters, mightier than the waves of the sea, the LORD on high is mighty!" (v. 4).
7. "Your decrees are very trustworthy" (v. 5).
8. "Holiness befits your house, O LORD, forevermore" (v. 5).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm opens with a proclamation: “The LORD reigns; he is robed in majesty; the LORD is robed; he has put on strength as his belt.” The Hebrew word for “reigns” can also be rendered “has become king,” and the psalm was probably sung to celebrate God’s kingship. He is clothed like a king in majesty and strength. “Yes, the world is established; it shall never be moved.” Because God is king, the world is stable. The world is not a random accident but is held in place by his rule.

Next, the eternity of his throne: “Your throne is established from of old; you are from everlasting.” Before the world existed, God reigned. His throne is not a recent achievement. This is why the elders in Revelation 4 praise the one who was and is and is to come.

Then the threat: “The floods have lifted up, O LORD, the floods have lifted up their voice; the floods lift up their roaring.” Three times, the floods are mentioned, building like waves. They represent every power that threatens: chaotic nature, hostile nations, and demonic forces. The floods are loud, and the repeated phrasing suggests that they will not stop. But the next verse puts them in perspective: “Mightier than the thunders of many waters, mightier than the waves of the sea, the LORD on high is mighty!” The floods roar, but God is mightier. His voice, in Psalm 29, is heard over the waters.

The psalm ends with two statements about God’s word and house. “Your decrees are very trustworthy; holiness befits your house, O LORD, forevermore.” His commands can be trusted, and his dwelling place is holy. The God who rules the floods is also the God who speaks reliably and calls his people to holiness.

For Christians, the picture is complete in Jesus, who stilled the storm with a word (Mark 4:39), walked on the waves, and calmed the seas that frightened his disciples. They said in awe, “Who then is this, that even wind and sea obey him?” This psalm is the answer. And in Revelation, the Lamb stands on the throne above the chaos, and the sea of glass before the throne is calm (4:6). In the new creation, “the sea was no more” (21:1): the symbol of chaos is gone.

STEP 5

## Connection

Psalm 29:3, 10 also pictures God enthroned over the flood. Psalm 95-99 are other enthronement psalms. Exodus 15:18 declares that the LORD will reign forever. Mark 4:35-41 shows Jesus calming the storm. Job 38:8-11 shows God setting limits for the sea. Psalm 65:7 and 89:9 speak of stilling the waves. Isaiah 43:2 promises that waters will not overwhelm. Revelation 4:6, 15:2, and 21:1 mention the sea. Revelation 11:15 and 19:6 announce that God reigns. Hebrews 12:28 speaks of receiving an unshakable kingdom.

STEP 6

## Application

When you feel like the floods are lifting up their voice (anxiety, news, conflict), say verse 4 aloud.

Thank God for the stability of his rule. Name three things in your life that rest on it.

Pray that your church's life would reflect the holiness that befits his house.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Praise God as king, robed in majesty.

Thank him that the world is established and cannot be moved.

Tell him what you are holding that you want him to uphold.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 127

"Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy."

REVELATION 15:3-4

DAY 887 · WEEK 127

# Psalm 97

*The LORD reigns; let the earth rejoice*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 12 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 97. It is another enthronement psalm. Notice how creation and the nations respond to the arrival of the King, and how the psalm ends with joy for the righteous.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 97 continues the theme of the previous psalm: the LORD reigns. It uses imagery of theophany (God's appearing), with clouds, fire, lightning, and melting mountains, similar to Sinai. It also speaks of the humiliation of idols and the joy of God's people. It reads like a commentary on Revelation 19, where the multitude cries, "Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns," and the idols and the powers of evil are overthrown.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "The LORD reigns, let the earth rejoice; let the many coastlands be glad!" (v. 1).
2. "Righteousness and justice are the foundation of his throne" (v. 2).
3. "The mountains melt like wax before the LORD, before the Lord of all the earth" (v. 5).
4. "The heavens proclaim his righteousness, and all the peoples see his glory" (v. 6).
5. "All worshipers of images are put to shame" (v. 7).
6. "O you who love the LORD, hate evil! He preserves the lives of his saints" (v. 10).
7. "Light is sown for the righteous, and joy for the upright in heart" (v. 11).
8. "Rejoice in the LORD, O you righteous, and give thanks to his holy name!" (v. 12).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Where Psalm 93 spoke of the stability of God's reign, Psalm 97 shows its effects. The first response is joy: "The LORD reigns, let the earth rejoice; let the many coastlands be glad!" Even distant lands are invited. But the reign of God is also awesome: "Clouds and thick darkness are all around him; righteousness and justice are the foundation of his throne." God's throne rests on righteousness and justice; he rules fairly. "Fire goes before him and burns up his adversaries all around. His lightnings light up the world; the earth sees and trembles. The mountains melt like wax before the LORD." This is similar to the plagues and cosmic disturbances of Revelation. The Lord's coming is overwhelming, and all of creation responds.

"The heavens proclaim his righteousness, and all the peoples see his glory." Then a result for false religion: "All worshipers of images are put to shame, who make their boast in worthless idols; worship him, all you gods!" Idols are shown to be empty. The gods themselves are told to worship the LORD, a statement that echoes Revelation, where the demonic powers are defeated. Zion hears and is glad, and the daughters of Judah rejoice "because of your judgments, O LORD." God's judgments are a cause of rejoicing for his people, because they mean justice at last. "For you, O LORD, are most high over all the earth; you are exalted far above all gods."

Then the moral application: "O you who love the LORD, hate evil! He preserves the lives of his saints; he delivers them from the hand of the wicked." Love for God and hatred of evil go together. And the promise: "Light is sown for the righteous, and joy for the upright in heart." The metaphor is of seeds in the ground: light and joy are planted for the righteous and will spring up. It may not look like it now, in a world that persecutes the saints, but a harvest of light and joy is coming. This is the same theme as in Revelation 21, where there is no more night and no more tears.

The final invitation is to rejoice: "Rejoice in the LORD, O you righteous, and give thanks to his holy name!" Believers face the future with joy. In Revelation, the final celebration is of the marriage supper of the Lamb. For now, we rejoice by faith, trusting that the day will come when the evidence matches the promise.

STEP 5

## Connection

Exodus 19:16-19 and Psalm 18:7-15 describe God's appearing. Psalm 96, 98, and 99 are other enthronement psalms. Isaiah 42:17 and 44:9-20 mock idols. Hebrews 1:6 quotes the Septuagint of verse 7, "Let all God's angels worship him." Psalm 89:14 says righteousness and justice are the foundation of his throne. Revelation 19:1-8 shows the multitude rejoicing at

God's judgments. Romans 12:9 says to abhor what is evil. Psalm 126:5-6 speaks of sowing with tears and reaping with joy. Revelation 21:23-25 pictures the city without need of the sun. Habakkuk 3:3-6 is another theophany.

STEP 6

## Application

Think of a situation where you cannot yet see justice, and picture "light sown" there. Pray for the harvest.

Hate what God hates this week. Ask him to show you something you have been tolerating.

Rejoice in the LORD today, even if circumstances are hard, and give thanks to his holy name.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Rejoice that the LORD reigns.
- Thank him for light sown for the righteous.
- Ask him to give you gladness in him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 127

"Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy."

REVELATION 15:3-4

DAY 888 · WEEK 127

# Revelation 16:1-21

*The seven bowls of wrath*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 21 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 16:1-21. The seven bowls of God's wrath are poured out in a rapid series, resembling the plagues of Egypt. Notice the repeated refusal to repent, the declaration that God's judgments are just, and the final cry, "It is done!"

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The bowls are the last of the series of seven (seals, trumpets, bowls). They are described as final, bringing the wrath of God to completion. Unlike the trumpets, which affected a third of the earth, the bowls are total. Interpreters differ on whether the three series are sequential, parallel, or progressively intensifying cycles that cover the same period from different angles. In any reading, the point is the same: God's judgment on the beast's kingdom is just and certain, and he will bring evil to account.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Go and pour out on the earth the seven bowls of the wrath of God" (v. 1).
2. "Harmful and painful sores came upon the people who bore the mark of the beast" (v. 2).
3. "Yes, Lord God the Almighty, true and just are your judgments!" (v. 7).
4. "They did not repent and give him glory" (v. 9).
5. "Its water was dried up, to prepare the way for the kings from the east" (v. 12).
6. "Behold, I am coming like a thief! Blessed is the one who stays awake" (v. 15).
7. "And they assembled them at the place that in Hebrew is called Armageddon" (v. 16).
8. "It is done!" (v. 17).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

A loud voice from the temple commands the seven angels to pour out the bowls. The first brings sores on those with the mark of the beast, like the boils of Egypt. The second turns the sea to blood, killing every living thing in it. The third turns the rivers and springs to blood, and the angel of the waters declares: “Just are you, O Holy One, who is and who was, for you brought these judgments. For they have shed the blood of saints and prophets, and you have given them blood to drink. It is what they deserve!” A voice from the altar adds, “Yes, Lord God the Almighty, true and just are your judgments!” This is the answer to the martyrs’ cry in 6:10: God’s judgments are retributive, matched to the sin. The fourth bowl scorches people with fire from the sun, “and they cursed the name of God who had power over these plagues. They did not repent and give him glory.” This is the tragic refrain: even under judgment, hearts remain hard. The fifth falls on the throne of the beast, and its kingdom is plunged into darkness; people gnaw their tongues in anguish and curse God, but do not repent of their deeds.

The sixth bowl dries up the great river Euphrates “to prepare the way for the kings from the east.” Three unclean spirits like frogs come from the mouths of the dragon, the beast, and the false prophet, performing signs and going out to assemble the kings of the whole world “for battle on the great day of God the Almighty.” Then the voice interrupts: “Behold, I am coming like a thief! Blessed is the one who stays awake, keeping his garments on, that he may not go about naked and be seen exposed!” This is a call to watchfulness in the midst of the vision. “And they assembled them at the place that in Hebrew is called Armageddon.” The name probably means “Mount of Megiddo,” a site of famous battles in Israel’s history (Judges 5; 2 Kings 23:29), though Megiddo is a plain, not a mountain, so it is a symbolic name for the place where the final battle is gathered. Interpreters differ on whether this is a literal military conflict at the end of history or a symbol of the final spiritual confrontation between the forces of evil and God. Notice that in the account no battle is described here; it is deferred to 19:19-21, where the beast and the kings gather against the rider on the white horse, and the battle is won by his word.

The seventh bowl is poured into the air, and a loud voice from the throne says, “It is done!” Flashes of lightning, rumblings, thunder, and a great earthquake, such as there has never been, split the great city into three parts, and the cities of the nations fall. “God remembered Babylon the great, to make her drain the cup of the wine of the fury of his wrath.” Every island flees, mountains vanish, and great hailstones, about a hundred pounds each, fall from heaven on people, and they curse God. The chapter ends as it began, with human hearts unrepentant.

This chapter is hard to read. We should neither dwell on it with relish nor skip over it. It tells us that God takes evil seriously. The same Lord who offers mercy will not let evil go unanswered. It also tells us something about the human heart: apart from grace, even the experience of God's judgment does not produce repentance. We need new hearts, and Christ gives them.

STEP 5

## Connection

Exodus 7-10 recounts the plagues of Egypt. Psalm 79:1-3 and Isaiah 49:26 relate to those who shed blood. Genesis 9:6 and Luke 11:49-51 speak of the blood of the prophets. Isaiah 11:15-16 and Jeremiah 50:38 describe drying up the Euphrates. Judges 5:19 and 2 Kings 23:29-30 mention Megiddo. Ezekiel 38-39 describes a final assault against God's people. Matthew 24:43-44 and 1 Thessalonians 5:2-4 describe the coming as a thief. Revelation 19:11-21 shows the final battle. John 19:30, "It is finished." Romans 2:4-5 speaks of an unrepentant heart.

STEP 6

## Application

Stay awake: think of one habit that helps you stay alert and watchful in your faith, and strengthen it this week.

Pray for someone with a hard heart, that God would grant repentance.

When you are struck by the justice of God's judgments, thank Christ for taking the wrath for those who trust in him.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Thank God that his judgments are true and just.
- Ask him to give you a tender heart that repents.
- Thank him that he hears the blood of his saints.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 127

“Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy.”

REVELATION 15:3-4

DAY 889 · WEEK 127

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Revelation 15:3-4 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"Great and amazing are your deeds, O Lord God the Almighty! Just and true are your ways, O King of the nations! Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy."

REVELATION 15:3-4

REST

## Meditation

This is a song sung by those who have come through great trouble. Standing on the shore of the sea of glass, with harps in hand, they sing about the character of God, not about themselves.

"Great and amazing are your deeds." They praise what he has done. "Just and true are your ways." They praise how he does it: with justice and truth, even when the ways are painful or hard to understand. The people who sing this have seen suffering, and they still say his ways are just.

"Who will not fear, O Lord, and glorify your name? For you alone are holy." The right response to a holy God is reverent fear and glad glory.

The song combines the song of Moses and the song of the Lamb: the exodus and the cross. When you feel confused by events, sing this to remind yourself of what will be said at the end.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week you read the second half of Revelation's visions of conflict. Chapter 14 showed the Lamb with his people on Mount Zion, the eternal gospel proclaimed to every nation, the fall of Babylon, the blessing on those who die in the Lord, and the final harvest. Chapter 15 gave us the song of Moses and the Lamb. Four psalms framed the reign of God: Psalm 2 (the nations rage, but God's Son is enthroned), Psalm 46 (God is our refuge, be still), Psalm 93 (the LORD reigns, mightier than the floods), and Psalm 97 (the LORD reigns, light is sown for the righteous). Chapter 16 poured out the seven bowls of wrath: judgments that are just, and hearts that do not repent, ending with the cry "It is done!"

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

Psalm 2 says, "Blessed are all who take refuge in him." What would it mean for you to take refuge in Christ this week, specifically from something that frightens you?

In Revelation 16, people suffer terrible judgments and still do not repent. What does this tell you about the human heart, and how does it increase your gratitude for grace?

Revelation 14:13 says those who die in the Lord are blessed, because they rest from their labors and their deeds follow them. How does this change how you think about death, and about the work you are doing now?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God that great and amazing are his deeds.

Thank him for his reign.

Rest in him.

DAY 890 · WEEK 128

# Revelation 17:1-18:24

*Babylon the great falls*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 42 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 17:1-18:24. Two chapters describe the fall of Babylon the great, first as a prostitute riding a beast, then as a great city mourned by merchants and kings. Notice the contrast between Babylon and the Bride of the Lamb, who appears in chapter 19.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

In the Old Testament, Babylon was the empire that destroyed Jerusalem and took Israel into exile, and it became the symbol of human pride and opposition to God, from the tower of Babel (Genesis 11) onward. In the first century, Babylon was a code name for Rome, the city on seven hills that dominated the Mediterranean world. In Revelation, Babylon is both of these and more: the world system organized against God, seductive, wealthy, and violent, in every age. The prophets Isaiah, Jeremiah, and Ezekiel used a similar language for the cities of Babylon and Tyre. John's readers would hear the echoes.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "And I saw a woman sitting on a scarlet beast that was full of blasphemous names" (17:3).
2. "I saw the woman, drunk with the blood of the saints, the blood of the martyrs of Jesus" (17:6).
3. "They will make war on the Lamb, and the Lamb will conquer them, for he is Lord of lords and King of kings" (17:14).
4. "Fallen, fallen is Babylon the great!" (18:2).
5. "Come out of her, my people, lest you take part in her sins, lest you share in her plagues" (18:4).

6. “I sit as a queen, I am no widow, and mourning I shall never see” (18:7).
7. “And slaves, that is, human souls” (18:13).
8. “Rejoice over her, O heaven, and you saints and apostles and prophets, for God has given judgment for you against her!” (18:20).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

One of the seven angels with the bowls invites John to see “the judgment of the great prostitute who is seated on many waters, with whom the kings of the earth have committed immorality.” In the Spirit, John sees a woman sitting on a scarlet beast with seven heads and ten horns, dressed in purple and scarlet, adorned with gold, jewels, and pearls, holding a golden cup full of abominations. On her forehead is a name of mystery: “Babylon the great, mother of prostitutes and of earth’s abominations.” She is “drunk with the blood of the saints, the blood of the martyrs of Jesus.” John marvels greatly, and the angel explains the mystery. The beast “was, and is not, and is to come” (a parody of God’s “who is and who was and who is to come”). The seven heads are seven mountains (an allusion to Rome’s seven hills) and also seven kings. The ten horns are ten kings who receive authority for a brief time. They give their power to the beast and “will make war on the Lamb, and the Lamb will conquer them, for he is Lord of lords and King of kings, and those with him are called and chosen and faithful.” The woman “is the great city that has dominion over the kings of the earth.” Interpreters debate the exact historical identification of the kings, but the point is that every earthly power that opposes Christ is doomed. And, strikingly, the beast and the ten kings turn on the prostitute and destroy her: evil devours itself.

In chapter 18, the scene shifts to the city’s fall. An angel with great authority lights up the earth: “Fallen, fallen is Babylon the great! She has become a dwelling place for demons, a haunt for every unclean spirit.” The reason is that all nations have drunk of the wine of her immorality, and the merchants of the earth have grown rich from the power of her luxurious living. Then a voice from heaven calls God’s people: “Come out of her, my people, lest you take part in her sins, lest you share in her plagues.” It is a call to separation. Believers are to live in the world without being of it, refusing its idolatries and injustices, and ready to leave if loyalty to Christ requires it. The prophets said the same of the ancient Babylon (Jeremiah 51:45).

The woman’s self-image is: “I sit as a queen, I am no widow, and mourning I shall never see.” Because of her pride, “in a single day her plagues will come, death and mourning and famine, and she will be burned up with fire.” The kings of the earth, merchants, and shipmasters mourn her: “Alas! Alas! You great city.” The merchants weep because “no one buys their cargo anymore.” The cargo list is long: gold, silver, jewels, fine linen, spices, wine,

grain, cattle, horses and chariots, “and slaves, that is, human souls.” The final item reveals the system’s true cost: human lives sold as commodities. The empire’s wealth was built on trafficking in people. Their grief is not for her but for their profits.

Heaven, however, responds with joy: “Rejoice over her, O heaven, and you saints and apostles and prophets, for God has given judgment for you against her!” A mighty angel throws a stone like a great millstone into the sea: “So will Babylon the great city be thrown down with violence, and will be found no more.” The sounds of harpists, musicians, craftsmen, millstones, lamps, and brides and grooms will cease. “And in her was found the blood of prophets and of saints, and of all who have been slain on earth.” All injustice is judged. The city of man is overthrown to make room for the city of God.

STEP 5

## Connection

Genesis 10-11 introduces Babel and Babylon. Isaiah 13-14, 21:9, 47, Jeremiah 50-51, and Daniel 4:30 describe ancient Babylon’s pride and fall. Ezekiel 26-28 describes the fall of Tyre. Nahum 3:4 uses prostitution for a city. Hosea 2 and Jeremiah 3 use prostitution for unfaithfulness. 2 Corinthians 6:14-18 and 1 John 2:15-17 call for separation from the world. Isaiah 52:11 and Jeremiah 51:6, 45 say “come out.” Ezekiel 27 lists the merchants of Tyre. Amos 8:4-6 and James 5:1-6 condemn exploiting the poor. 1 Peter 5:13 uses Babylon for Rome.

STEP 6

## Application

Ask where you are drawn by the glamor and luxury of Babylon. What do you envy or chase that the world offers?

Consider the supply chains and systems you depend on. Ask whether any of them are built on the exploitation of people, and what you can do about it.

Pray for believers living in places of persecution and temptation, that they would be kept faithful.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Worship Jesus as Lord of lords and King of kings.

Thank him that Babylon has fallen and he has won.

Ask him to help you come out of whatever you are entangled with.

**MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 128**

“He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen.”

**REVELATION 22:20-21**

DAY 891 · WEEK 128

# Revelation 19:1-20:15

*The marriage supper; the rider; the thousand years; final judgment*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 61 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 19:1-20:15. This is a long and important reading, covering the marriage supper of the Lamb, the rider on the white horse, the binding of Satan, the thousand years, and the great white throne. Read slowly, and notice how each scene answers the question of who wins.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

After the fall of Babylon, heaven erupts in praise, and the book moves to the return of Christ, the final defeat of evil, and the last judgment. Chapter 20 contains the only mention of the "thousand years" in the Bible, and Christians have understood it in three major ways. The book's purpose is not to settle a timetable but to assure the church that the Lamb wins and that evil is finally and fully destroyed.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns" (19:6).
2. "The marriage of the Lamb has come, and his Bride has made herself ready" (19:7).
3. "Blessed are those who are invited to the marriage supper of the Lamb" (19:9).
4. "A white horse! The one sitting on it is called Faithful and True" (19:11).
5. "King of kings and Lord of lords" (19:16).
6. "And bound him for a thousand years" (20:2).
7. "Blessed and holy is the one who shares in the first resurrection!" (20:6).
8. "And if anyone's name was not found written in the book of life, he was thrown into the lake of fire" (20:15).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

A great multitude in heaven cries out, “Hallelujah! Salvation and glory and power belong to our God, for his judgments are true and just; for he has judged the great prostitute.” These are the only “Hallelujahs” in the New Testament. The twenty-four elders and four living creatures say “Amen,” and a voice from the throne calls all God’s servants to praise. Then the multitude, “like the roar of many waters and like the sound of mighty peals of thunder,” cries, “Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns. Let us rejoice and exult and give him the glory, for the marriage of the Lamb has come, and his Bride has made herself ready; it was granted her to clothe herself with fine linen, bright and pure,” which is “the righteous deeds of the saints.” This is a contrast with the prostitute. The Bride is the church. “Blessed are those who are invited to the marriage supper of the Lamb.” John falls down to worship the angel, but is told, “You must not do that! I am a fellow servant… Worship God. For the testimony of Jesus is the spirit of prophecy.”

Then heaven opens: “a white horse! The one sitting on it is called Faithful and True, and in righteousness he judges and makes war.” His eyes are like a flame of fire, on his head are many diadems, he wears a robe dipped in blood, and his name is “The Word of God.” The armies of heaven follow him on white horses, clothed in fine linen. “From his mouth comes a sharp sword with which to strike down the nations.” Note that the weapon is his word. On his robe and thigh is written the name “King of kings and Lord of lords.” An angel invites the birds to the great supper of God. The beast and the kings gather to make war against him, but the beast and the false prophet are captured and thrown alive into the lake of fire, and the rest are killed by the sword from his mouth. No battle is actually described: the Word speaks and it is done.

In chapter 20, an angel with the key of the bottomless pit seizes “the dragon, that ancient serpent, who is the devil and Satan, and bound him for a thousand years, and threw him into the pit, and shut it and sealed it over him, so that he might not deceive the nations any longer.” Then John sees thrones with those given authority to judge, and the souls of those beheaded for the testimony of Jesus, who “came to life and reigned with Christ for a thousand years.” This is called the first resurrection. “Blessed and holy is the one who shares in the first resurrection! Over such the second death has no power.” After the thousand years, Satan is released for a short time, deceives the nations (Gog and Magog), and surrounds the camp of the saints, but fire comes down from heaven and consumes them, and the devil is thrown into the lake of fire.

Christians have three main views on the millennium. Premillennialists believe Christ returns before a literal thousand-year reign on earth: historic premillennialists hold that the church will go through the tribulation, and dispensational premillennialists hold that the

church is raptured before it. Amillennialists believe the thousand years is symbolic of the present age between Christ's first and second comings, in which Satan is bound in the sense that he cannot prevent the gospel from reaching the nations, and the saints who have died reign with Christ in heaven. Postmillennialists believe that the gospel will bring a golden age before Christ returns. Faithful Christians hold each of these views. The points on which all agree are that Christ will return visibly, there will be a resurrection and judgment, and the final state is the new creation.

The chapter ends with the great white throne, which we examine on Day 892: the dead, great and small, stand before the throne, books are opened, and death and Hades are thrown into the lake of fire. The last enemy is destroyed.

STEP 5

## Connection

Psalm 2 and 110 are the background of the rider's rule with the rod of iron. Isaiah 63:1-6 describes the one whose garments are stained. Ephesians 5:25-32 and 2 Corinthians 11:2 describe the church as the Bride. Isaiah 25:6-9 describes a feast on the mountain. Matthew 22:1-14 and 25:1-13 are parables of the wedding. 2 Thessalonians 2:8 says Christ will destroy the lawless one by the breath of his mouth. Ezekiel 38-39 describes Gog and Magog. John 5:28-29 and 1 Corinthians 15:20-28 speak of resurrection and the last enemy. Colossians 2:15 and Matthew 12:29 speak of binding the strong man.

STEP 6

## Application

Praise God today with the word "Hallelujah," and think about what it means: "praise the LORD."

Think of the marriage supper of the Lamb as your future. Ask how it changes what you live for now.

When Christians disagree on the millennium, practice charity. Which parts do all agree on, and how can you focus on them?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Say, "Hallelujah," and tell God why.

Thank him for inviting you to the marriage supper of the Lamb.

Ask him to keep you faithful to the end.

**MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 128**

“He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen.”

**REVELATION 22:20-21**

DAY 892 · WEEK 128

# Revelation 20:11-15; Matthew 25:31-46; 2 Corinthians 5:10

*The Final Judgment*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Doctrine

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 20:11-15, Matthew 25:31-46, and 2 Corinthians 5:10. Today is a doctrinal pause on the final judgment. It is a serious subject, so read slowly, and notice both the justice and the mercy that appear in these passages.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Christians have confessed from the earliest days that Christ "will come again to judge the living and the dead." The final judgment is not a minor topic; Jesus spoke of it often, and the apostles preached it. It is meant to produce reverence, sobriety, and urgency, and for believers, thankfulness and hope. We must handle it with care because it concerns real people and eternal consequences.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Then I saw a great white throne and him who was seated on it" (Revelation 20:11).
2. "And I saw the dead, great and small, standing before the throne, and books were opened" (Revelation 20:12).
3. "The dead were judged by what was written in the books, according to what they had done" (Revelation 20:12).
4. "And if anyone's name was not found written in the book of life, he was thrown into the lake of fire" (Revelation 20:15).
5. "He will separate people one from another as a shepherd separates the sheep from the goats" (Matthew 25:32).

6. “As you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me” (Matthew 25:40).
7. “And these will go away into eternal punishment, but the righteous into eternal life” (Matthew 25:46).
8. “For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ, so that each one may receive what is due for what he has done in the body, whether good or evil” (2 Corinthians 5:10).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

## Doctrinal Focus

The final judgment is the public, universal, and final assessment by Christ of every human being at the end of history. The Bible teaches several truths about it.

It is certain. God “has fixed a day on which he will judge the world in righteousness by a man whom he has appointed” (Acts 17:31). Jesus himself is the judge (John 5:22; 2 Timothy 4:1), which means the one who died for sinners is the one before whom all will stand. It is universal: “the dead, great and small.” No one is overlooked or excused.

It is according to truth and works. The books record what each person has done, and the judgment will be perfectly just. Nothing is hidden (Luke 12:2-3; Romans 2:16). Works are the evidence of the heart. Yet no one is saved by works. The decisive question is whether one’s name is in the book of life, the book of the Lamb who was slain (Revelation 13:8; 21:27). Those who are in Christ are declared righteous by faith, and “there is therefore now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1). Believers will also appear before the judgment seat of Christ, but not for condemnation. Paul says the judgment will evaluate their works, to bring rewards or loss, “yet so as through fire” (1 Corinthians 3:12-15). Their salvation is secure, and their service will be rewarded by grace. The judgment of the nations in Matthew 25 shows that how people treat Christ’s people (the “least of these”) shows their relationship to him.

It results in two outcomes. The Bible teaches the final separation of the saved and the lost: eternal life and eternal punishment (Matthew 25:46; Daniel 12:2). The majority of Christian teaching throughout history has understood this punishment as conscious and everlasting, and this view has strong support in Matthew 25:41-46, Mark 9:43-48, 2 Thessalonians 1:9, and Revelation 14:11 and 20:10. A minority of evangelicals, including some respected teachers such as John Stott, have argued for conditional immortality or annihilationism, the view that the lost will be destroyed and cease to exist after judgment, pointing to passages that speak of “destruction” and “perishing.” The universalist view, that all will eventually be saved, has been rejected by the church as contrary to Scripture’s clear teaching. We should handle this topic with humility, not with relish. “As I live, declares the Lord GOD, I have no pleasure in the death of the wicked” (Ezekiel 33:11).

What should we do with this doctrine? It should fill us with a sober urgency to share the gospel (2 Corinthians 5:11), with confidence that God will right every wrong (Romans 12:19), with comfort for those who suffer injustice, and with humility, because we also deserve judgment apart from grace. It should lead us to live in a way that is pleasing to the Lord (2 Corinthians 5:9). And it should drive us to Christ, who bore the judgment for all who trust him, so that on that day we can stand in him.

STEP 4

## Interpretation

John sees a great white throne. The white signifies purity, and the throne's size signifies the greatness of the occasion. "From his presence earth and sky fled away, and no place was found for them." The old creation cannot stand before the Judge. The dead are raised, "great and small," and stand before the throne. Books are opened, and "another book was opened, which is the book of life." The books record deeds, the book of life records the names of those who belong to the Lamb. The sea, Death, and Hades give up their dead. Then "Death and Hades were thrown into the lake of fire. This is the second death, the lake of fire. And if anyone's name was not found written in the book of life, he was thrown into the lake of fire."

Matthew 25 gives a parable of the same event. The Son of Man sits on his throne of glory, and all nations are gathered before him. He separates people as a shepherd separates sheep from goats. To the sheep he says, "Come, you who are blessed by my Father, inherit the kingdom prepared for you from the foundation of the world." The basis he names is care for the hungry, thirsty, stranger, naked, sick, and imprisoned. They are astonished: when did we do these things? "As you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me." The goats are told to depart into the eternal fire prepared for the devil and his angels. Neither group is aware of the full significance of what they did. The sheep did not do these things to earn a reward; their love was the fruit of a transformed heart. The goats' lack of love revealed that they did not know him.

Paul writes with sobering clarity: "For we must all appear before the judgment seat of Christ." It says "all," including Christians. And he draws the implication: "Therefore, knowing the fear of the Lord, we persuade others." But he also explains the ground of confidence: "For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God" (2 Corinthians 5:21). We can look forward to the day not because we are good but because we are covered in Christ's righteousness.

STEP 5

## Connection

Acts 17:30-31 and Romans 2:5-16 speak of the day of judgment. John 5:22-29 says the Father has given all judgment to the Son. 1 Corinthians 3:10-15 and 4:5 speak of the testing of works. Romans 14:10-12 says we will all stand before God's judgment seat. Hebrews 9:27 says people die once and then face judgment. Ecclesiastes 12:14 says God will bring every deed into judgment. Daniel 12:1-3 speaks of resurrection to everlasting life and contempt. Romans 8:1 and John 5:24 promise no condemnation for believers. 2 Peter 3:7-9 speaks of the patience of God. Ezekiel 18:23 says God takes no pleasure in the death of the wicked.

STEP 6

## Application

Take a few minutes to thank Christ for bearing the judgment you deserved. Read Romans 8:1 aloud.

Ask who in your life does not yet know Christ, and pray for them by name. Take one step to speak to them.

Look at Matthew 25 and ask: whom might you serve this week as if you were serving Christ himself?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Thank Jesus for being judge and also the one who bore judgment for you.
- Tell him what you want to say about the final judgment.
- Pray for someone you love who does not yet trust him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 128

"He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen."

REVELATION 22:20-21

DAY 893 · WEEK 128

# Revelation 21:1-22:5

*The new creation; the New Jerusalem; the river of life*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 32 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 21:1-22:5. This is the climax of the whole Bible: the new heavens and new earth, the New Jerusalem, and the river and tree of life. Read slowly. As you read, think back to the first chapters of Genesis, and notice how many things in the Garden of Eden return here.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The book of Revelation ends with the vision for which the whole Bible has been preparing: God dwelling with his people in a renewed creation. The images are drawn from Isaiah 65-66, Ezekiel 40-48, and Zechariah, and from Genesis 1-3. Where Genesis began with a garden and a marriage, Revelation ends with a city and a marriage. What was lost in the fall is restored and surpassed. This is the goal of the covenants: God with his people. It is why the memory verse for this unit comes from this passage.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. “Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and the sea was no more” (21:1).
2. “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God” (21:3).
3. “He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more” (21:4).
4. “Behold, I am making all things new” (21:5).
5. “And its lamp is the Lamb” (21:23).
6. “The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations” (22:2).

7. “No longer will there be anything accursed” (22:3).

8. “They will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads” (22:4).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

John sees “a new heaven and a new earth, for the first heaven and the first earth had passed away, and the sea was no more.” The sea, a symbol of chaos and separation, is gone. Then he sees “the holy city, new Jerusalem, coming down out of heaven from God, prepared as a bride adorned for her husband.” The city is the people of God, and the image of the bride unites the two. Then the voice from the throne: “Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God.” This is the covenant promise, repeated throughout the Old Testament (Leviticus 26:11-12; Ezekiel 37:27): “I will be their God, and they shall be my people.” The tabernacle and temple were pointers; here the reality has arrived. “He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away.” The curse of Genesis 3 is undone.

The one on the throne speaks for the second time in the book: “Behold, I am making all things new.” Not “I am making new things,” but all things new. It is a renewal of creation. “I am the Alpha and the Omega, the beginning and the end. To the thirsty I will give from the spring of the water of life without payment.” Those who conquer will inherit these things, “and I will be his God and he will be my son.” But the cowardly, faithless, detestable, murderers, sexually immoral, sorcerers, idolaters, and all liars will have their portion in the lake of fire. The vision does not hide the stakes.

An angel shows John the Bride, the wife of the Lamb: the holy city, with the glory of God, radiant like a jewel. It has a great high wall with twelve gates, with the names of the twelve tribes of Israel, and twelve foundations with the names of the twelve apostles of the Lamb. Old and new covenant people are united. The city is a perfect cube (12,000 stadia each way), like the Most Holy Place in the temple. The whole city is a holy of holies. The wall is jasper, the city pure gold, clear as glass, and the foundations are adorned with every kind of jewel. The gates are pearls, and the street is pure gold. “And I saw no temple in the city, for its temple is the Lord God the Almighty and the Lamb.” “And the city has no need of sun or moon to shine on it, for the glory of God gives it light, and its lamp is the Lamb.” The nations walk by its light, and the kings of the earth bring their glory into it. Its gates are never shut, for there is no night. “But nothing unclean will ever enter it… but only those who are written in the Lamb’s book of life.”

Chapter 22 returns to Eden. “Then the angel showed me the river of the water of life, bright as crystal, flowing from the throne of God and of the Lamb through the middle of the street of the city; also, on either side of the river, the tree of life with its twelve kinds of fruit, yielding its fruit each month. The leaves of the tree were for the healing of the nations. No longer will there be anything accursed, but the throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his servants will worship him. They will see his face, and his name will be on their foreheads. And night will be no more. They will need no light of lamp or sun, for the Lord God will be their light, and they will reign forever and ever.” The tree of life, lost in Genesis 3, is restored. The river of Eden, now from the throne. And the greatest promise: “They will see his face.” This is the beatific vision, which no one could have and live (Exodus 33:20). Because of Christ, we will see God’s face, and we will reign with him.

STEP 5

## Connection

Genesis 1:1-2:25 and 3:22-24 are the beginning that Revelation completes. Isaiah 65:17-25 and 66:22 promise new heavens and a new earth. Ezekiel 37:26-28 and 47:1-12 describe God dwelling with his people and a river from the temple. Leviticus 26:11-12 and 2 Corinthians 6:16 repeat the covenant formula. Isaiah 25:8 and 35:10 promise no more tears. Isaiah 60:1-3, 19-20 pictures nations coming to the light. 1 Kings 6:20 describes the cube-shaped Most Holy Place. Ephesians 2:19-22 and Galatians 4:26 speak of the heavenly Jerusalem. Psalm 17:15 and 1 John 3:2 speak of seeing God. Matthew 5:8 promises the pure in heart will see God.

STEP 6

## Application

Read the memory verse (21:3-4) aloud, slowly. Which promise most touches your situation today: no more tears, no more death, no more pain?

Imagine the tree of life and the river. How would knowing that this is where history is headed shape the way you spend the day?

Think of someone who is grieving. Share verse 4 with them, and sit with them.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God that he will dwell with his people and wipe away every tear.

Tell him what tears you are bringing him.

Ask him to give you hope for the new creation.

**MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 128**

“He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen.”

**REVELATION 22:20-21**

DAY 894 · WEEK 128

# Revelation 21:1-22:5; Isaiah 65:17-25; 2 Peter 3:10-13

*The New Heavens and New Earth*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Doctrine

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 21:1-22:5, Isaiah 65:17-25, and 2 Peter 3:10-13. Today is a doctrinal pause on the new heavens and new earth: the final destiny of believers and of creation. Notice how the Old Testament prophecy, Peter's teaching, and John's vision fit together.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

What is heaven like? Many Christians imagine the final state as a spiritual realm where disembodied souls float on clouds, but the Bible's picture is richer and more physical. The final hope of the believer is not escaping the world but a renewed world, with resurrected bodies in a restored creation, in which God dwells with his people. Getting this right shapes how we value creation, work, and our present life.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "For behold, I create new heavens and a new earth, and the former things shall not be remembered or come into mind" (Isaiah 65:17).
2. "They shall build houses and inhabit them; they shall plant vineyards and eat their fruit" (Isaiah 65:21).
3. "The wolf and the lamb shall graze together" (Isaiah 65:25).
4. "The day of the Lord will come like a thief" (2 Peter 3:10).
5. "But according to his promise we are waiting for new heavens and a new earth in which righteousness dwells" (2 Peter 3:13).
6. "Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth" (Revelation 21:1).

7. “Behold, I am making all things new” (Revelation 21:5).

8. “The throne of God and of the Lamb will be in it, and his servants will worship him” (Revelation 22:3).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

## Doctrinal Focus

The Bible’s final hope is the new heavens and new earth. Four features stand out.

First, it is a renewed creation, not a mere escape. God created the world and called it very good. The fall corrupted it, but God does not abandon his creation. Paul says that “the creation itself will be set free from its bondage to corruption and obtain the freedom of the glory of the children of God” (Romans 8:21). Christ’s death and resurrection are the first fruits of the renewal of all things (Colossians 1:20). Christians differ on how much continuity there is between the present creation and the new one. Many Reformed teachers hold that the new earth will be a purification and renewal of this one (as the flood cleansed but did not destroy the earth), while some, including many Lutherans, hold that God will annihilate the present world and create a wholly new one. In either case, the new creation is physical, real, and glorious, and what we do now in faith is not in vain (1 Corinthians 15:58).

Second, it includes the resurrection of the body. We will not be disembodied spirits. When Christ returns, the dead in Christ will be raised, and the living changed, so that we have glorified bodies like his (Philippians 3:20-21; 1 Corinthians 15:42-54). Those who die before then are “with Christ, which is far better” (Philippians 1:23) in a conscious intermediate state, as we saw in Unit 21, but the final hope is resurrection on the new earth.

Third, it is the fulfillment of the covenants. In Genesis 1-2, God made humanity to dwell with him in a garden and to rule creation. Abraham was promised land, and Paul says he was promised “the world” (Romans 4:13). The Israelites who longed for the promised land were looking toward “a better country, that is, a heavenly one” (Hebrews 11:16), “the city that has foundations” (Hebrews 11:10). David’s throne is fulfilled in the reign of Christ. The new covenant, with its promise of forgiveness and God dwelling with his people, comes to its full fruition. In progressive covenantalism, all the covenants find their fulfillment in Christ and his people in the new creation: the land becomes the whole earth, the temple becomes God’s presence with all, and the people of God are drawn from all nations.

Fourth, it is a place of worship, rest, work, and joy. The picture includes seeing God’s face (Revelation 22:4), the absence of sin, death, and tears, the reign of the saints with Christ (22:5), the healing of the nations, and the glory of the nations being brought in (21:24-26). Isaiah 65 includes houses, vineyards, and long life, which suggests meaningful work and

enjoyment, without frustration. There will be rest, as the Sabbath points forward (Hebrews 4:9-11). The center of it all is God himself. As the old catechism says, our chief end is to glorify God and enjoy him forever.

So how should this hope shape us? It gives us courage in suffering (Romans 8:18), motivates holy living (2 Peter 3:11-14), directs our affections toward the things above (Colossians 3:1-4), and prompts us to care for the creation that God will renew. It gives dignity to the work we do now. And it fills us with longing: "Come, Lord Jesus!"

STEP 4

## Interpretation

Isaiah 65 is the Old Testament source. God promises new heavens and a new earth, and Jerusalem as a joy. The former things will be forgotten. There will be no more weeping, no more infant mortality, and people will live long. They will build houses and inhabit them, plant vineyards and eat their fruit, no longer for others to take. The wolf and the lamb will graze together; the lion shall eat straw like the ox, and "they shall not hurt or destroy in all my holy mountain." This is a picture of peace, justice, and flourishing. John in Revelation 21 sees the fulfillment on a larger scale.

Peter, in 2 Peter 3, addresses scoffers who say that all things continue as they were. He declares that the day of the Lord will come like a thief, with the heavens passing away with a roar, and the elements dissolved with heat. As we saw on Day 852, this can be read as the purging of the creation by fire. And then the application: "Since all these things are thus to be dissolved, what sort of people ought you to be in lives of holiness and godliness, waiting for and hastening the coming of the day of God?" The hope is the incentive to holiness.

Taken together, these passages show that Christians are not waiting for evacuation but for new creation. Paul's, Peter's, Isaiah's, and John's visions harmonize: the world will be made right, and God will dwell here with his people.

STEP 5

## Connection

Genesis 1:31, 3:17-19, and Romans 8:18-25 trace creation, fall, and redemption. Colossians 1:15-20 and Ephesians 1:9-10 speak of reconciling all things in Christ. Matthew 19:28 mentions the renewal of all things. Acts 3:21 speaks of the restoration of all things. Philippians 3:20-21 and 1 Corinthians 15:35-58 speak of resurrection bodies. Psalm 37:11 and Matthew 5:5 promise the meek will inherit the earth. Hebrews 11:8-16 and Romans 4:13 speak of the promised world. 1 Thessalonians 4:13-18 describes Christ's return. Habakkuk 2:14 and Isaiah 11:6-9 describe the earth filled with the knowledge of the LORD.

STEP 6

## Application

Think about what you imagined heaven would be like. How does the picture of a renewed earth change it?

Choose one way to care for God's creation this week (a neighbor's yard, a garden, a recycling habit, a walk), as an expression of hope.

Do some of your normal work today as something that will not be wasted in God's new world.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God for the promise of new heavens and a new earth.

Ask him to help you live as a citizen of that world now.

Tell him what you long for there.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 128

"He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen."

REVELATION 22:20-21

DAY 895 · WEEK 128

# Revelation 22:6-21

*Come, Lord Jesus, the final words of Scripture*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Reading · 16 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Revelation 22:6-21. These are the final words of the Bible. Notice how Jesus speaks directly, repeating "I am coming soon," and how the book ends with an invitation and a prayer.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

The visions are over. The angel confirms that "these words are trustworthy and true." What follows is a series of closing statements, partly from the angel, partly from Jesus, partly from John, that function as an epilogue. They return to the themes of the beginning: blessing for those who keep the words, the identity of Christ as Alpha and Omega, the coming of Jesus, and grace. The Bible ends not with a doctrine but with a prayer: "Come, Lord Jesus!"

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "And behold, I am coming soon. Blessed is the one who keeps the words of the prophecy of this book" (v. 7).
2. "Behold, I am coming soon, bringing my recompense with me" (v. 12).
3. "I am the Alpha and the Omega, the first and the last, the beginning and the end" (v. 13).
4. "Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that they may have the right to the tree of life" (v. 14).
5. "I am the root and the descendant of David, the bright morning star" (v. 16).
6. "The Spirit and the Bride say, Come. And let the one who hears say, Come" (v. 17).
7. "Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!" (v. 20).
8. "The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen" (v. 21).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The angel says, “These words are trustworthy and true. And the Lord, the God of the spirits of the prophets, has sent his angel to show his servants what must soon take place.” Then Jesus speaks: “And behold, I am coming soon. Blessed is the one who keeps the words of the prophecy of this book.” This is the sixth of seven blessings. John falls to worship the angel again, and again is told, “You must not do that! I am a fellow servant… Worship God.” Even at the climax of the revelation, only God deserves worship. And John is told, “Do not seal up the words of the prophecy of this book, for the time is near.” The message is not meant to be hidden but to be lived in the present. “Let the evildoer still do evil, and the filthy still be filthy, and the righteous still do right, and the holy still be holy.” The time to respond is now.

Then Jesus speaks again: “Behold, I am coming soon, bringing my recompense with me, to repay each one for what he has done. I am the Alpha and the Omega, the first and the last, the beginning and the end.” He claims the titles of God. Then the last of the seven blessings: “Blessed are those who wash their robes, so that they may have the right to the tree of life and that they may enter the city by the gates.” Outside are the dogs, sorcerers, sexually immoral, murderers, idolaters, and everyone who loves and practices falsehood. Recall 7:14: robes are washed in the blood of the Lamb. This is grace, not merit.

Jesus gives his credentials: “I, Jesus, have sent my angel to testify to you about these things for the churches. I am the root and the descendant of David, the bright morning star.” He is the fulfillment of the promises to David and the herald of a new day (2 Peter 1:19). Then the Spirit and the Bride (the church) say, “Come.” This is the church’s prayer for the return of the Lord, and perhaps also an invitation to those who have not yet believed. “And let the one who hears say, Come. And let the one who is thirsty come; let the one who desires take the water of life without price.” The last invitation of the Bible is an open one. Anyone who is thirsty can come and drink freely.

A warning follows, which has often been applied to the whole Bible: “If anyone adds to them, God will add to him the plagues described in this book, and if anyone takes away from the words of the book of this prophecy, God will take away his share in the tree of life and in the holy city.” It applies first to this book, and by extension to all of God’s word. We are to receive it as it is, neither adding nor subtracting.

The last words belong to Jesus and to John. “He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon.” And John answers: “Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!” The Aramaic form of this prayer, Maranatha, was a cry of the earliest church (1 Corinthians 16:22). The Bible, which began with “In the beginning, God,” ends with grace: “The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen.” The story that began in a garden ends in a city, but throughout, it is the story of the grace of God.

STEP 5

## Connection

Revelation 1:1-3 parallels the opening. Revelation 7:14 and 22:14 speak of washing robes. Isaiah 55:1 and John 7:37-38 invite the thirsty. Numbers 24:17 and 2 Peter 1:19 mention the star. Isaiah 11:1, 10 speaks of the root of Jesse. Deuteronomy 4:2 and 12:32 warn against adding to or taking from God's word. 1 Corinthians 16:22 contains the prayer Maranatha. Matthew 24:42-44 and 25:13 call us to watchfulness. Titus 2:13 speaks of waiting for the blessed hope. John 14:3 and Acts 1:11 promise Christ's return. 2 Timothy 4:8 speaks of loving his appearing. Genesis 1:1 begins the story.

STEP 6

## Application

Make Day 895's final prayer part of your daily rhythm: "Come, Lord Jesus." Say it at the end of the day.

If you are thirsty, accept the invitation of verse 17. If someone you know is thirsty, extend it to them.

Re-commit to receive the Bible as God's complete word, neither adding to it nor taking from it, and to keep reading it.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Worship Jesus as the Alpha and the Omega.
- Pray, "Come, Lord Jesus," and tell him what you want when he comes.
- Ask him to keep you faithful to his word.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 128

"He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen."

REVELATION 22:20-21

DAY 896 · WEEK 128

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Revelation 22:20-21 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"He who testifies to these things says, Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus! The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all. Amen."

REVELATION 22:20-21

REST

## Meditation

These are the last words of the Bible, and they are a prayer. After sixty-six books, after every promise, warning, and story, the book ends with a longing: "Come, Lord Jesus!"

The words belong to Jesus first: "Surely I am coming soon." He promises. And then the church answers: "Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!" We do not just wait; we long. This is not a nervous prayer but the prayer of a bride for her husband.

And then, a benediction: "The grace of the Lord Jesus be with all." The Bible, which opens with creation, ends with grace. We have no claim on God but this: the unearned favor of the Lord Jesus. Everything depends on it.

Pray these words today, and let your longing for his return increase. Come, Lord Jesus.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This week you reached the climax of Revelation. Chapters 17 and 18 showed the fall of Babylon, the world system drunk with the blood of the saints, and the call to come out of her. Chapter 19 gave the marriage supper of the Lamb and the rider on the white horse, Faithful and True, with the word of God as his sword. Chapter 20 showed Satan bound, the thousand years (understood in three main ways), and the great white throne. On Day 892, we paused on the final judgment, in which Christ judges with justice, and those in him are not condemned. Chapters 21 and 22 showed the new heavens and new earth, with God dwelling with his people, no more tears, the tree of life, the river, and the sight of his face. On Day 894, we paused on the hope of a renewed creation. And Revelation 22:6-21 gave the final words of the Bible: Jesus is coming soon, the thirsty may take the water of life, and the church prays, "Come, Lord Jesus."

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

Revelation 18 shows Babylon's wealth built partly on trafficking in human lives. What do you see in your own culture or economy that resembles this, and what is one concrete thing you can do about it?

Revelation 21:3-4 promises God's dwelling with us, no more tears, and no more death. Which of these promises means the most to you today, and who in your life needs to hear it?

The Bible ends with the prayer, "Come, Lord Jesus!" Do you pray this, and mean it? What are the things that make you hold on to this world, and what would it look like to long for his coming more?

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank Jesus for rest and for the hope of his return.

Pray, "Come, Lord Jesus."

Ask him to prepare you.

DAY 897 · WEEK 129

# Psalm 72:18-19

*Blessed be the LORD; his glory fills the earth*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 2 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 72 in full, giving special attention to the closing doxology in verses 18 and 19. This is a prayer for the king, and it closes the second book of the Psalter. Notice how a prayer for a human king grows into a prayer for the whole earth to be filled with God's glory.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

Psalm 72 is a psalm "of Solomon," or perhaps for Solomon, a prayer that the king would rule with God's justice and bring blessing to the nations. It ends Book II of the Psalter with a doxology (vv. 18-19) and a note: "The prayers of David, the son of Jesse, are ended." The psalm describes a king far greater than any Israel ever had: one whose reign extends from sea to sea, whose name endures forever, and through whom all nations are blessed. This is the promise to Abraham (Genesis 12:3) and to David (2 Samuel 7), and the New Testament sees its fulfillment in Jesus. In Revelation, kings do bring their glory into the city (21:24), and the whole earth is filled with the glory of the Lord.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Give the king your justice, O God, and your righteousness to the royal son!" (v. 1).
2. "May he defend the cause of the poor of the people, give deliverance to the children of the needy, and crush the oppressor!" (v. 4).
3. "May he have dominion from sea to sea, and from the River to the ends of the earth!" (v. 8).
4. "May all kings fall down before him, all nations serve him!" (v. 11).
5. "May people be blessed in him, all nations call him blessed!" (v. 17).

6. “Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, who alone does wondrous things” (v. 18).
7. “Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!” (v. 19).
8. “The prayers of David, the son of Jesse, are ended” (v. 20).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The psalm begins as a prayer for the king: “Give the king your justice, O God, and your righteousness to the royal son!” The test of a good king is whether he rules with God’s justice. Specifically, “May he defend the cause of the poor of the people, give deliverance to the children of the needy, and crush the oppressor!” The poor are the king’s first concern. Justice for the vulnerable is central to a godly government and to the reign of Christ.

The prayer then pictures a reign of peace and abundance: “May the mountains bear prosperity for the people, and the hills, in righteousness!” The king will be like rain on mown grass, like showers that water the earth. “In his days may the righteous flourish, and peace abound, till the moon be no more!” His rule extends “from sea to sea, and from the River to the ends of the earth.” Foreign kings bring tribute: “May the kings of Tarshish and of the isles render him tribute; may the kings of Sheba and Seba bring gifts! May all kings fall down before him, all nations serve him!” This echoes the gifts of the wise men to the infant Christ and the vision of the nations bringing their glory into the New Jerusalem. The reason is again compassion: “For he delivers the needy when he calls, the poor and him who has no helper. He has pity on the weak and the needy, and saves the lives of the needy.” He redeems their lives from oppression and violence, and “precious is their blood in his sight.”

The prayer reaches its high point in verse 17: “May his name endure forever, his fame continue as long as the sun! May people be blessed in him, all nations call him blessed!” This is an echo of the Abrahamic promise: “in you all the families of the earth shall be blessed” (Genesis 12:3). No merely human king could fulfill this. Solomon’s reign had a golden beginning but ended in compromise, and the kings after him fell. The psalm remained a prayer for a king who would fulfill it. Jesus is that King. He defends the poor, saves the needy, and brings blessing to all nations. “Behold, something greater than Solomon is here” (Matthew 12:42).

The psalm ends with a doxology that closes Book II: “Blessed be the LORD, the God of Israel, who alone does wondrous things. Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!” The prayer for the king becomes a prayer for God’s glory over the whole earth. This is the goal of everything: not the king’s honor but the glory of God. The doxology answers Numbers 14:21 and anticipates Habakkuk 2:14. And then the note, “The prayers of David, the son of Jesse, are ended.” The prayers of a man end, but the

prayer for God's kingdom goes on in the prayer Jesus taught us: "Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven." It will be answered fully in the new creation, when the whole earth is filled with his glory.

STEP 5

## Connection

2 Samuel 7:12-16 and Genesis 12:1-3 are the promises behind the psalm. 1 Kings 3-10 shows Solomon's reign. Matthew 2:1-12 shows kings bringing gifts to Jesus. Matthew 12:42 and Luke 1:32-33 declare Jesus greater than Solomon. Isaiah 11:1-9 and 9:6-7 describe the righteous king. Numbers 14:21 and Habakkuk 2:14 speak of the earth filled with God's glory. Matthew 6:10 is the prayer for his kingdom to come. Psalm 41:13, 89:52, and 106:48 are the other doxologies closing the books of the Psalter. Revelation 5:9-14, 11:15, and 21:24-26 show the nations and kings worshiping.

STEP 6

## Application

Pray Matthew 6:10 slowly: your kingdom come, your will be done. Name one place where you long to see his justice.

Ask how you can "defend the cause of the poor" in a practical way this month through your time, giving, or voice.

End your day with verse 19: "Blessed be his glorious name forever; may the whole earth be filled with his glory! Amen and Amen!"

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Bless the LORD who alone does wondrous things.

Thank him for the true King, Jesus.

Ask him to fill the earth with his glory.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 129

“For all the promises of God find their Yes in him. That is why it is through him that we utter our Amen to God for his glory.”

2 CORINTHIANS 1:20

DAY 898 · WEEK 129

# Psalm 150

*Let everything that has breath praise the LORD, Amen*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Psalm · 6 verses

THE READING

## Read the passage

Read Psalm 150 again, slowly and aloud. You first met it as trumpets in Revelation 8 to 11. Now read it as the last psalm of the Psalter, the last chapter of your journey, and a summary of what the whole Bible is for.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

STEP 2

## Setting the Scene

This is the second time in this unit that we read Psalm 150, and we are glad to return to it. The first time, it prepared us for the trumpets of judgment, and the last time, it is a closing word: the whole Psalter, with all its tears and joys, ends in praise. The same is true of the Bible's whole story. After every lament, every warning, and every war, the last word is "Hallelujah." In Revelation, the word "Hallelujah" (which means "Praise the LORD") appears in 19:1-6, the only place in the New Testament where it is found.

STEP 3

## Observation

1. "Praise the LORD! Praise God in his sanctuary" (v. 1).
2. "Praise him in his mighty heavens!" (v. 1).
3. "Praise him according to his excellent greatness!" (v. 2).
4. "Praise him with lute and harp!" (v. 3).
5. "Praise him with strings and pipe!" (v. 4).
6. "Praise him with loud clashing cymbals!" (v. 5).
7. "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD!" (v. 6).
8. "Praise the LORD!" (v. 6).

STEP 4

## Interpretation

The whole book of Psalms is a conversation between God's people and God. It contains songs of trust and complaint, history and prophecy, kings and exiles. Its structure follows a path. The first Psalm begins with the blessed man who delights in God's law, and the book ends with the entire creation breathing praise. It begins with a person and ends with the cosmos. It begins with study and ends with song.

The five verses of the psalm are a final summary of all the praise of the Psalter. Praise is to be given in "his sanctuary" and in "his mighty heavens"; in the earthly place of worship and in the heavenly one. We praise him "for his mighty deeds," a summary of what he has done in creation, the exodus, the covenant, the exile and return, and finally in Christ. We praise him "according to his excellent greatness," because who he is exceeds anything we can say. The music is all the instruments of Israel's worship. Whether we have a trained voice or a tin ear, we can join the praise. And then the invitation to everyone: "Let everything that has breath praise the LORD!" The Hebrew word for breath (neshamah) is the word used in Genesis 2:7, when God breathed into Adam the breath of life. Every breath is a gift, and every breath is an invitation to praise.

Now we read it as the end of a journey. For 900 days, we have traveled through the story of God, from creation to new creation. We have seen the creation, the fall, the call of Abraham, the exodus, the law, the kings, the exile, the return, the coming of Christ, the cross, the resurrection, the birth of the church, the letters to the churches, and the vision of the end. In all of it, we have seen a God who keeps his covenant. The story ends not in despair but in praise. And the psalm that ends the Psalter is a template for the end of our lives: whatever our circumstances, we end in praise. And in Revelation 19, the multitude shouts "Hallelujah" four times. This is the sound of the new creation, and we can begin practicing it now.

"Let everything that has breath praise the LORD! Praise the LORD!" In the Hebrew, the last word of the Psalter is Hallelujah. Say it with the church of every age. Hallelujah.

STEP 5

## Connection

Genesis 2:7 mentions the breath of life. Psalm 1 is the opening of the Psalter. Psalm 145-149 are the other closing psalms of praise. Revelation 19:1-6 has the four Hallelujahs of the great multitude. Revelation 5:11-14 shows the whole creation praising. Ephesians 5:18-20 and Colossians 3:16-17 call for praise in the church. Hebrews 13:15 says to continually offer a sacrifice of praise. Philippians 2:10-11 sees every tongue confessing. Isaiah 43:21 says God

formed his people to declare his praise. 1 Peter 2:9 says we are called to proclaim his excellencies. Romans 11:36 gives a doxology: from him and through him and to him are all things.

STEP 6

## Application

Take a moment to look back at what God has done in your life over these years. Name three things that stand out, and thank him.

Sing or speak Psalm 150 aloud, and finish with a loud "Hallelujah."

Let each breath today be a reminder that you were made to praise the LORD.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Praise the LORD in your own words, for his mighty deeds.
- Thank him for what he has done over these days.
- Let everything that has breath praise him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 129

"For all the promises of God find their Yes in him. That is why it is through him that we utter our Amen to God for his glory."

2 CORINTHIANS 1:20

DAY 899 · WEEK 129

# Review and Reflection

*Unit 25 review, The New Covenant Consummated, Revelation*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Review

MEMORY

## Unit Verse

> "Behold, the dwelling place of God is with man. He will dwell with them, and they will be his people, and God himself will be with them as their God. He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away."
>
> REVELATION 21:3-4

REST

## Meditation

This is the memory verse for the final unit, and the destination of the whole Bible. Notice how it begins: "Behold." It is a call to look. After all of history, John is told to look at what God has done.

"The dwelling place of God is with man." The Hebrew Scriptures speak of God's tabernacle, the glory in the temple, and the promise "I will be their God, and they shall be my people." The story began in a garden, where God walked with Adam and Eve. Sin separated us. Christ came, "and the Word became flesh and dwelt among us" (John 1:14). And now God dwells with us forever.

Then the promise: "He will wipe away every tear." God personally wipes tears. It is the picture of a tender Father. "Death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away." Every grief that you carry will be answered.

Say this verse to yourself in the hardest moments, and say it to someone who is grieving. It is not wishful thinking. It is a promise from the one who said, "Behold, I am making all things new."

LOOK BACK

## Unit Recap

This final unit took us through the book of Revelation, in which all of God's covenant promises find their Yes in Christ. In chapters 1 to 3, we saw the risen Christ among his churches, and his letters calling them to love, faithfulness, and repentance. In chapters 4 and 5, we entered the throne room, where the Lion of Judah is a Lamb who was slain, worthy to open the scroll of history. The seals, trumpets, and bowls showed God's judgment on a rebellious world and the church's call to endure, with the sealed multitude from every nation. Chapters 12 and 13 unmasked the dragon and the beasts, and showed that the saints conquer by the blood of the Lamb, by the word of their testimony, and by not loving their lives even unto death. Chapters 17 to 20 showed the fall of Babylon, the marriage supper of the Lamb, Christ's return, the defeat of Satan, and the final judgment. Chapters 21 and 22 revealed the new heavens and new earth, with God dwelling with his people, the river and tree of life, and the final invitation, "Come." Psalms 1, 19, 29, 141, 150, 148, 2, 46, 93, 97, and 72 provided songs along the way: the two ways, creation and word, the voice of the LORD, prayers as incense, praise, and the reign of God. The doctrinal pauses covered the final judgment and the new creation.

REFLECT

## Review Questions

How does Revelation draw on imagery from every major section of the Old Testament?

Choose two images from Revelation (for example, the tree of life, the plagues, or the temple) and trace where they come from in the Old Testament.

What does it mean that the Lamb who was slain holds the scroll of history?

In your own words, explain how Christ's death is the key to history, and how this might change the way you see current events.

How do Revelation 21 and 22 fulfill the promises of Genesis 1 and 2?

List three things from the Garden of Eden that return in the new creation, and say what each tells you about God's purpose.

Looking back: where do you see God's covenant faithfulness from beginning to end?

Name three moments in the Bible's story where God kept his promises, and one moment in your own life where you have seen his faithfulness.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

- Thank God that he will dwell with you and wipe away every tear.
- Tell him what you have seen of the Lamb in Revelation.
- Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.

DAY 900 · WEEK 129

# Sabbath Rest

*No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.*

Year 2 · Unit 25 · Sabbath

THE READING

## Today's reading

This is the last day of the plan. There is no new reading today. Read 2 Corinthians 1:20 slowly, several times, and try to say it from memory. Then read the meditation and the look back below, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

*Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.*

MEMORY

## Memory Verse for the Week

"For all the promises of God find their Yes in him. That is why it is through him that we utter our Amen to God for his glory."

2 CORINTHIANS 1:20

REST

## Meditation

You have made it to the end of 900 days. That is a remarkable thing, and God gets the glory. Whether you read every day or caught up after missing weeks, you have been through the whole Bible and the heart of the Christian faith.

This verse is a good summary of what you have read. "All the promises of God find their Yes in him." In Genesis, God promised a seed who would crush the serpent. He promised Abraham a blessing for all nations. He promised David a son who would reign forever. He promised a new covenant, forgiveness, a new heart, his Spirit, and a new creation. Every promise, big or small, finds its Yes in Jesus Christ.

"That is why it is through him that we utter our Amen to God for his glory." Because the promises are fulfilled in Christ, we can say "Amen," meaning "so be it, we trust you," to everything God says. The Bible began with God speaking and ends with the church saying

“Amen.”

You do not finish the Bible; it keeps reading you. This is a place to begin, not an end. Where do you go from here? Keep reading, and read the Bible again, now that you know the story. Pick a book and read it slowly, with a study Bible or commentary. Stay rooted in a local church, where you can hear the word preached, receive the Lord’s Supper, and be loved and corrected. Pray the Psalms. Memorize Scripture. Teach someone else what you have learned. Start again at Day 1 with a friend. And hold on to Christ: he is the Yes to every promise, and he will hold on to you.

LOOK BACK

## The Week in Review

This final stretch of the plan took you from the fall of Babylon to the new Jerusalem. You read of the marriage supper of the Lamb, the rider on the white horse, the binding of Satan, the great white throne, the new heavens and new earth, and the last words of the Bible: “Surely I am coming soon. Amen. Come, Lord Jesus!” Psalm 72 prayed for the true King through whom all nations will be blessed, and Psalm 150 ended the Psalter with praise. Day 899 reviewed the whole of Revelation. And now you have finished the whole plan: the story of creation, fall, redemption, and new creation, told across the Old Testament, the Gospels, Acts, the letters, and Revelation, with the key doctrines of the Christian faith along the way. From Genesis 1:1 to Revelation 22:21, the Bible tells one story, whose center is Jesus Christ. God has been faithful from beginning to end.

REFLECT

## Questions for Reflection

Looking back over the 900 days, what is one truth about God that you understand better now than when you began? How has it changed the way you pray, live, or think?

Paul says that all the promises of God find their Yes in Christ. Which promise, from anywhere in the Bible, has become most precious to you, and how do you see it fulfilled in Jesus?

What is one concrete step you will take in the next month to keep growing: a reading habit, a church community, a person to disciple or be discipled by? Write it down and tell someone.

PRAY

## Respond in Prayer

*Talk to God in your own words. You might:*

Thank God for these 900 days in his word, naming something he has done in you.

Thank him that every promise finds its yes in Jesus.

Ask him to keep you reading, praying, and following for the rest of your life.